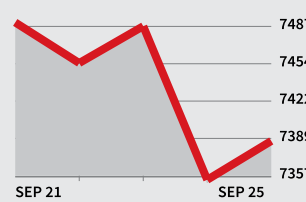


SENSEX 73895.74 (+315.20)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23140.50	+77.40
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	19.62	+0.09
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.81	-0.15
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	151504.00	+1323
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	232350.00	+4102

POLICY SUPPORT.

Global steel prices to stay above

2025 levels despite weak construction demand, say analysts **p8**



AUTO FOCUS.

India-made BMW i5 eDrive 35L offers premium luxury at a compelling price **p4**

BENGALURU • CHENNAI • COIMBATORE • HUBBALLI • HYDERABAD • KOCHI • KOLKATA • MADURAI • MALAPPURAM • MANGALURU • MUMBAI • NOIDA • THIRUVANANTHAPURAM • TIRUCHIRAPPALLI • VIJAYAWADA • VISAKHAPATNAM

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QUICKLY.

WOONG INVESTORS

Govt to overhaul bilateral investment treaty norms



New Delhi: The government is set to overhaul the model bilateral investment treaty (BIT) framework, with the new text likely to be taken up by the Union Cabinet soon. But taxation and the jurisdiction of domestic courts will remain outside the scope of investor protection provisions, top government sources said. **p3**

HIGH INPUT COSTS

Another price hike on the cards: Tata Motors PV MD

New Delhi: Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles (PV) has indicated another round of price hikes in the coming days as input costs continue to rise because of geopolitical issues. Asked about the impact of GST 2.0, which had created a positive sentiment over the past year, Shailesh Chandra, MD and CEO, Tata Motors PV, said it would continue despite a rise in vehicle prices, which are still better compared to the pre-GST reforms last year. **p2**

US tariff threat: India 'will not' compromise on energy security

KEY TARGET. Minister Goyal to reiterate stance during US visit next week; China gets relief

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal's bilateral discussions with US officials on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting in Milwaukee next week, are expected to centre around the Lindsey Graham legislation targeting buyers of Russian energy, particularly in the light of the exemption granted to Beijing until January 2027, sources said.

Experts noted that New Delhi must hold firm on its stated policy of "no compromise" on India's energy security especially considering that the sanctions law, which empowers US President Donald Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on major buyers of Russian energy, now has India as the primary target.

"The US and China have extended the Busan Agreement to January 10, 2027, preventing new bilateral trade tariffs. This leaves India as the sole major target country under the new US

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal **ANI**

law," said Ajay Srivastava of the Global Trade and Research Initiative (GTRI).

NO LASTING RELIEF

India must not trade its energy security for temporary tariff relief or sign an unequal Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) because surrendering to these demands will offer no lasting defence, as history demonstrates, he added.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has already made it clear that India will not compromise on its national interest and Com-

merce Minister Piyush Goyal is likely to express the same in interactions in the US next week, said former JNU professor Biswajit Dhar.

"After the Lindsey Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 was approved by the US Congress, the MEA response was very clear: Come what may, India is going to battle it out. There can be no compromise on this. The Commerce Minister is likely to say exactly the same thing, that we will look after our national interest," Dhar said.

In a September 17 state-

ment on the legislation, the MEA said India had conveyed to senior US officials that the move could affect bilateral relations and global energy markets, while remaining committed to energy security for its 1.4 billion people through diversified sourcing.

BILATERAL TRADE

While there is no official confirmation on Goyal's meetings with US officials on the sidelines of G20 Trade Ministers' meeting, the Commerce Secretary had earlier indicated that he (the minister) may meet US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer and discussions could touch upon the BTA under negotiation. India must insist on the US not implementing the Lindsey Graham Act against it and be ready with retaliatory plans, said Abhijit Das, an expert on international trade and WTO matters.

"India must clearly convey that if any additional tariff is imposed on it, it would respond with commensurate measures to protect its interests," he said.

Centre further trims borrowing plan on tax buoyancy; relief for bond yields

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The government has further scaled down its total borrowing for the current fiscal year, setting a ₹7.86 lakh crore target for the October-March period.

Backed by strong tax collections that cut total planned borrowing by over ₹1.2 lakh crore, the strategy signals stronger-than-budgeted tax revenues and ease pressure on bond yields.

However, economists cautioned that the trimmed borrowing calendar does not necessarily mean the government's overall borrowing requirement has reduced as it could still resort to supplementary borrowing later in the fiscal depending on tax and non-tax revenues, disinvestment receipts and fiscal pressures.

On February 1, the Union Budget proposed total gross borrowing of ₹17.2 lakh crore. Since the Budget presentation, switches of G-Secs were conducted, reducing this amount to ₹16.09 lakh crore. Now, with the announcement of the second-half calendar, the total borrowing will be ₹15.99 lakh crore, including the plan for over ₹7.86 lakh crore during

SCALING DOWN

- Strong tax collections cut full-year borrowing target sharply
- Gross borrowing falls from budgeted ₹17.20 lakh crore
- Economists warn supplementary borrowing may still arise later

the October-March half.

According to Finance Ministry sources, net market borrowings (market borrowings for fiscal deficit financing) are kept at the Budget level, implying that, in spite of the incipient fiscal pressures, the "government is committed to the path of fiscal prudence laid out in the Budget". The sources added that the focus on the long end will "help us increase weighted average maturity (WAM), which had fallen during H1". A longer WAM will help reduce the roll-over risk, a source said.

According to a Finance Ministry statement, borrowing during the second half of FY27 will be spread across securities with tenors of 3, 5, 7, 10, 15, 30, 40 and 50 years.

Economists feel the good tax momentum is a key reason for the lower borrowing. Devendra Pant, Chief Economist, India Ratings & Research, said the Centre's fiscal deficit in April-July 2026 was 26.8 per cent of FY27 BE. Direct tax collection has remained strong in the first four months of the current fiscal; corporation tax and income tax grew 20.8 per cent and 24.3 per cent till July.

CUSTOM DUTIES

Pant said, "A weaker rupee has resulted in Customs duties growing 38.2 per cent and a limited de-growth of indirect tax to 0.5 per cent during 4MFY27. Strong growth momentum and expected higher nominal GDP growth in FY27 is expected to lead to higher direct tax growth."

But some economists are sceptical. "The announced borrowing plan for 2026-27 does not necessarily imply that the budgeted amount of borrowing has been brought down. GoI can always undertake supplementary borrowing if the conditions warrant it, which will be known only towards the end of the fiscal year," said DK Srivastava, Chief Policy Advisor, EY India.

Record \$94.53 billion inflows in FY26 take cumulative FDI since 2014-15 to \$843 billion

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India's foreign direct investments (FDI) touched a record \$94.53 billion in 2025-26 with cumulative inflows since 2014-15 increasing to \$843 billion, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday.

The Minister noted that the production linked incentive (PLI) schemes had given a momentum to manufacturing, attracting significant investments.

HIGHEST-EVER

"The numbers tell an encouraging story," Goyal said in a post on 'X' on Friday, noting that India recorded its highest-ever annual FDI inflow in 2025-26.

Greenfield industrial

smart cities are being set up across the country under the National Industrial Corridor Development Programme to build infrastructure for globally competitive manufacturing, the Minister said in his post marking the 12th anniversary of the 'Make in India' campaign.

"Ease of Doing Business reforms have simplified regulations and reduced the compliance burden, while reforms in key sectors have created new opportunities for investment and manufacturing," he added.

PLI PLAN, A SUCCESS

On the government's flagship PLI scheme, Goyal said that it had generated considerable momentum.

"As of March 31, 2026, they have resulted in ₹2.4 lakh crore of actual invest-

REFORMS ARE PAYING OFF

The PLI schemes added momentum to manufacturing and attracted significant investments

ment, ₹23.8 lakh crore in production/sales and ₹15.2 lakh crore in exports, while generating over 14.6 lakh direct and indirect jobs," the Minister pointed out.

WOONG INVESTMENT

The government has an approved outlay of ₹1.91 lakh crore for the PLI programme, which seeks to expand domestic manufacturing, attract investment, boost exports and reduce import dependence.

"Sectors such as electron-

ics and telecom, pharmaceuticals, medical devices, automobiles, IT hardware and speciality steel have significantly benefited from the PLI schemes," he said.

DIGITAL COMMERCE

Goyal also highlighted the role of the Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC) in expanding market access for small enterprises and bringing them into the digital commerce ecosystem.

The government-backed open network enables sellers, including small businesses and local enterprises, to connect with consumers through multiple buyer applications rather than being dependent on a single e-commerce platform.

"More than 470 crore orders have been placed on ONDC so far," he said.

FESTIVITIES CONCLUDE



DEVOTIONAL SEND-OFF. People shower confetti as the 'Lalbaugcha Raja' idol of Lord Ganesha is taken for immersion on the occasion of Anant Chaturdashi, marking the culmination of the Ganesh Chaturthi festivities in Mumbai on Friday **PTI**

AI effect: IT stocks turn wobbly; Infosys near July low, Wipro hits a new 52-week bottom

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

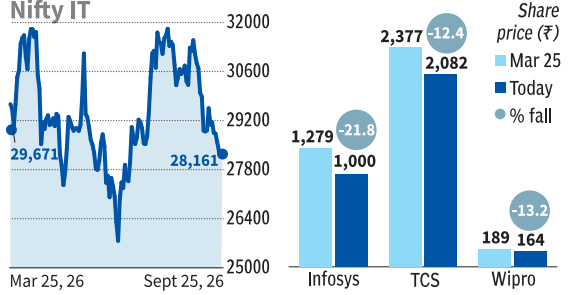
Information technology stocks remained under pressure on Friday, with large-cap names such as Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), Coforge and Mphasis ending lower as investors continued to reassess the sector's growth prospects amid rapid advances in artificial intelligence (AI) and broader market uncertainty.

Infosys and Oracle Financial Services Software were among the worst performers. Infosys slipped below ₹1,000 for the second time this year to ₹998, levels last seen on July 1.

While TCS declined 0.24 per cent, Coforge and Mphasis also came under selling pressure.

Wipro, despite featuring among the gainers during the session, touched a fresh 52-

Under constant pressure



week low of ₹161.66, falling below its previous July trough.

VOLATILE MARKET

The weakness in IT stocks comes against the backdrop of a volatile market environment. The Nifty 50 and the BSE Sensex recovered modestly on Friday after Thursday's sharp sell-off, rising 0.34 per cent and 0.43 per cent, respectively.

However, both benchmarks still recorded their

seventh consecutive weekly decline, the longest losing streak since 2020.

The pain has been more pronounced in technology stocks than in the broader market. The Nifty IT index has fallen about 21.5 per cent over the past year, compared with an 8 per cent decline in the Nifty 50.

Over the last six months, the Nifty IT has slipped about 2.4 per cent, underperforming the benchmark index's nearly 1.8 per cent

fall, reflecting the industry's transition to AI-led business models.

AI CONUNDRUM

"Indian companies are not seen as proxies to AI companies. They are still considered to be in the brick-and-mortar business. Yet, they are building AI capacities and upskilling employees. Therefore, though Infosys is attractive in terms of valuations, it is a contrarian move to invest in the large-caps. The next coming quarters and years will be crucial for all companies with regards to AI," said Kranthi Bathini, Director, Equity Strategy at WealthMills Securities.

Bathini, however, noted that Indian IT companies had successfully navigated previous disruptions, demonstrating their ability to adapt during periods of economic stress.

Tamil Nadu moves to top of equity FDI table in Q1

Surge driven by Shriram Finance deal, momentum in manufacturing, GCC investments

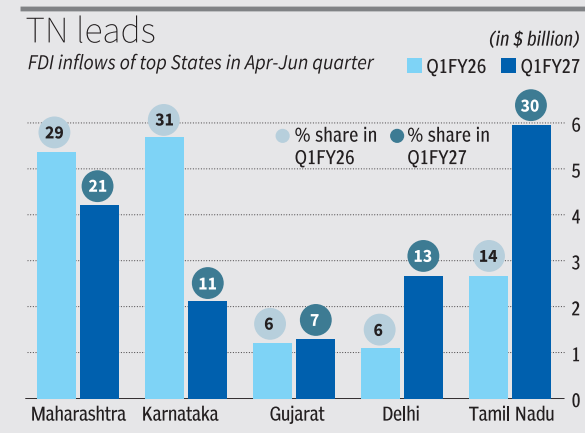
Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Tamil Nadu emerged as India's leading destination for FDI equity inflows in the first quarter of FY27 with foreign direct investment flows into the State more than doubling.

Official data show that Tamil Nadu attracted \$5.9 billion in FDI equity flows in April-June 2026, accounting for 30 per cent of India's total FDI equity inflows during the quarter. This is more than double the \$2.7 billion FDI the State got in Q1FY26.

The jump can be largely attributed to the large FDI inflow into Tamil Nadu-registered Shriram Finance from Japanese major MUFG. Analysts, however, add that the growth is also indicative of TN's ability to attract both manufacturing and GCC investments.

For instance, in the cur-



rent quarter (July-September), the industrialised State has already recorded two major GCC investments from the US, including pharma major Walgreens and coffee giant Starbucks.

In contrast, traditional FDI leaders Karnataka and Maharashtra saw steep year-on-year decline of 63

per cent and 21 per cent respectively, while FDI into Gujarat rose just 8 per cent.

Karnataka's share of FDI dropped from 31 per cent of India's total flows in Q1FY26 to 11 per cent in Q1FY27. Maharashtra remains a major destination but lost ground, with its share dropping from 29 per cent to 21 per cent.

Flows into the services sector, which includes financial, banking, insurance, business, outsourcing and R&D, more than doubled to \$7 billion in Q1FY27 from \$3.3 billion in Q1FY26.

While this includes the Shriram-MUFG deal, analysts also attribute inflows to the momentum in new GCC units in the country.

FDI JUMP

Gaurav S Ghosh, Associate Partner at Grant Thornton Bharat, said Tamil Nadu's FDI jump is significant, even though it is largely explained by a single transaction. "The structural momentum in the State's investments is seen in the last few years," he said.

On the decline in other top States, he noted a high base effect in the case of Karnataka and a broader trend reversal in Maharashtra.

QUICKLY.

Tata extends pact for green steel project



London: Tata Steel on Friday announced the extension of a sustainable production pact with a province in the Netherlands. Tata Steel originally signed a joint letter of intent with two key Dutch ministries and the Province of North Holland in 2025. The company said the five-month extension is intended to allow the parties more time to reach a final tailor-made agreement and to come to a final investment decision. **PTI**

Chevron, IIT-M launch hub for energy entrepreneurs

Chennai: Chevron Engine (Engineering and Innovation Excellence Center), the GCC arm of American Energy Giant Chevron, in collaboration with IIT Madras, has launched the Chevron-IIT-M Energy Technology Incubation programme. The programme will support early-stage innovators, researchers and social entrepreneurs working in technology-led solutions for energy infrastructure, carbon utilisation, circular economy and resource efficiency for the energy sector. Selected teams will receive tailored support based on their stage of development. **OUR BUREAU**

Blue Cloud bags \$15.5 m order from IBM Cloud



Hyderabad: Global Impx Inc (GIX), an arm of Blue Cloud Softech Solutions Ltd, has bagged an order worth \$15.5 million from IBM Cloud Inc for AI infrastructure design, deployment and support services. Work on the order began on September 24, and the fee will be paid after fixed milestones. The work includes assessing AI workloads, followed by high-level architecture and detailed design. **OUR BUREAU**

Decathlon strengthening play in running gear biz

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

Decathlon is strengthening its India play while eyeing a bigger share of the running gear segment. The sports goods manufacturer and retailer, which aims to double its India revenue by 2030, is witnessing double-digit growth. It aims to garner a turnover of ₹1,000 crore by 2030 from its expert running sub brand, Kiprun by Decathlon. “Kiprun by Decathlon is a strategic launch for us at a time when the running-gear segment is growing rapidly in the country. The sector is expected to grow in double digits over the next five years,” said Sankar Chatterjee, CEO, Decathlon India.

GROWING MARKET From 600-odd marathons and running events in 2018, he said, India has seen the number of such events go up to more than 2,000 today. “Even though we are launching the top of the range of products, we are pricing them competitively. We are aiming to achieve a running sport turnover of more than ₹1,000 crore by 2030 serving over five million active runners through the full product portfolio which includes shoes, apparel, trail gear, hydration pack and accessories,” he added. The Indian running-gear market is expected to nearly double to \$4.9 billion by 2034, per estimates by the IMARC Group.

Another price hike in the offing: Tata Motors PV MD

GRIM PROSPECT. Blames high input costs; says hikes so far not on par with GST 2.0 cuts

S Ronendra Singh

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles has said there could be another round of price hikes in the coming days as input costs continue to grow because of geopolitical issues. When asked about the impact of GST 2.0, which has created a positive sentiment over the last year, Shailesh Chandra, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, Tata Motors PV, said it will continue despite a rise in vehicle prices, which are still better as compared to pre-GST reforms last year.

MARGIN PRESSURE “It could be a sub-five per cent price increase so far by any manufacturer, from the time of GST. And, even after GST, opportunistically original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) could have taken a price increase more aggressively, but rather, after GST there were more discounts also, in the market. I think the first thing which has gone away is the discounting because supply is slightly behind the demand,” Chandra told *businessline* on the sidelines of a new launch



COMPACT SEDAN. Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles MD & CEO Shailesh Chandra on Friday launched AERIS, to be sold only to private customers and not fleet or taxi services

here. He said the price increase had not been to the extent of the reduction in GST. “Still, there is a significant headroom, and that is why the demand is unfolding at this level. But, yes, growth rates will come down,” he said, adding that the inability to pass on commodity-cost increases at the same pace was putting pressure on margins, requiring greater focus on cost reduction. “But, whenever we take

wholesales (dispatches to dealers) at 65,253 units in August, compared with 41,001 units in the same month last year.

NEW LAUNCH The company, on Friday, launched a new compact sedan — AERIS — priced between ₹5.29 lakh and ₹9.19 lakh (ex-showroom, introductory prices). It will replace the Tigor compact sedan and will be sold only to private customers for personal use and not for fleet or taxi services, Chandra said. The AERIS will be available in petrol and CNG versions, and going forward, the electric version of the car will also be offered, he said.

VOLUMES RISING Talking about compact sedan, Chandra said the market is about 3.40 lakh units in a year, and although the share has been declining in the overall sedan segment, the volume of compact sedan is increasing. “In just the last one year, it has grown 25-26 per cent, so it is a growing segment in terms of size. It also has a GST impact. So there is a clear section of customers looking for a compact sedan,” he added.

Dabur India gets NCLT nod to merge hair-care brand Sesa Care

Our Bureau

FMCG major Dabur India on Friday said it has received the National Company Law Tribunal’s (NCLT) approval for its merger with ayurvedic hair-care brand Sesa Care. The merger will complement the company’s existing hair-care portfolio and enable it to tap into new growth opportunities, it added.

HUGE POTENTIAL “The NCLT approval is an important milestone in our journey with Sesa Care. Sesa Care is a premium brand and complements our existing hair-care portfolio well. We see significant potential in bringing the two businesses together and building Sesa Care into a stronger and larger brand,” said Mohit Malhotra, CEO, Dabur India. “We will look to leverage Dabur India’s extensive distribution network, category expertise and access to key international markets to expand Sesa Care’s reach and unlock revenue and cost synergies from the combined business,” the company’s Executive Director and Group Head of Corporate Strategy, Abhinav Dhali, said. The company said that the merger will become effective upon completion of the necessary statutory filings.

Welspun Corp bags a record ₹4,000 cr pipe order from US

Our Bureau

Welspun Corp has secured its largest-ever order for high-frequency induction welded (HFIW) pipes, valued at around \$412.5 million (nearly ₹4,000 crore), with the pipes to be manufactured at the company’s upgraded facility in Little Rock, Arkansas, in the US.

HFIW pipes are widely used in transporting oil, natural gas, and water, among other things. The order, won by Welspun Tubular LLC, the company’s wholly owned US subsidiary, is the largest in the company’s history in terms of volume, length and value, Welspun Corp said in a stock exchange filing on Friday. The order is scheduled to be executed during FY28 and FY29.

ORDER BOOK GAIN The latest win has pushed Welspun Corp’s global order book to a record \$4.7 billion (around ₹45,000 crore), according to the company. The pipes will be manufactured at the upgraded HFIW mill at Little Rock, which has enhanced capabilities. The company said the order underscores the scale and execution capabilities of

HUGE WIN

- The order is the largest in the company’s history in terms of volume, length and value
- This has pushed Welspun Corp’s global order book to a record \$4.7 billion

its US operations and strengthens its strategy of expanding manufacturing capacity in international markets. Welspun Corp has been expanding its manufacturing footprint in the US as part of its strategy to serve customers closer to their markets and strengthen its position in the global pipe business. The company did not disclose the identity of the customer or the specific project. The record order comes as Welspun Corp continues to build its international order pipeline, with the US remaining an important market for its pipe business. The company said the latest contract also reinforces its long-term relationships with international customers and demonstrates the capabilities of its upgraded US manufacturing operations.

Suzuki Corp bets on smaller-battery REEVs as India emerges as key hub

Amit Vijay Mohile

Suzuki Motor Corp has added its range-extender electric vehicles (REEVs) technology to its global product roadmap, giving fresh momentum to a powertrain that JSW MG Motor India and other automakers are evaluating as India searches for alternatives to large-battery electric vehicles.

‘LEAN-BATTERY’ The Japanese automaker plans to develop a new class of REEVs that combine a smaller battery with an on-board generator, offering another pathway for EV adoption as manufacturers grapple with battery costs, charging infrastructure gaps

and range anxiety. “Each country has its own generation mix and fuel conditions; the state of infrastructure development is also different, so the optimal power source varies by region,” Suzuki Motor Corp President Toshihiro Suzuki said while outlining the company’s Technology Strategy 2026 in Japan on Friday. India is increasingly becoming the proving ground for Suzuki’s multi-powertrain strategy spanning battery EVs, hybrids, CNG and compressed biogas, while also growing in importance as a manufacturing and export hub. “Technology is shared. Products are regionally optimised,” Suzuki said, explaining how technologies developed in Japan are trans-



Each country has its own generation mix and fuel conditions... so the optimal power source varies by region

TOSHIHIRO SUZUKI
President, Suzuki Motor Corp

The company has not disclosed battery capacity, electric-only range or engine specifications, nor con-

firming an India launch timeline. Suzuki is not alone in exploring the space. Mahindra & Mahindra is developing range-extender solutions based on its EV architecture, according to people familiar with the company’s product plans. JSW MG Motor India has also publicly committed to the technology. Director Parth Jindal has said the company plans to introduce range-extender EVs, while its ADAPT (Advance Drive Architecture Platform Technology) is designed to support REEVs alongside battery EVs and plug-in hybrids.

THE CHALLENGE He has pointed to the technology’s rapid growth in China and its potential to address range anxiety. “Range extenders could offer a compelling bridge for India because they allow automakers to size the battery around everyday driving rather than the occasional long-distance journey. That can reduce battery cost and weight while addressing two of the biggest barriers to EV adoption, range anxiety and dependence on public charging infrastructure,” said Randheer Singh, CEO of automotive consulting firm ForeSee Advisors. “The bigger question will be how India classifies and taxes these vehicles. If range extenders are to sit between hybrids and pure EVs as a distinct technology, their economics will have to work for both manufacturers and consumers,” Singh said.

Centre earmarks ₹776 crore to upgrade EV testing infrastructure

Amit Vijay Mohile

Electric two-wheelers accounted for nearly one in every 10 two-wheelers sold in India during April-August 2026. This, even as the Centre approved the deployment of ₹776.29 crore to strengthen testing infrastructure for EVs and other emerging automotive technologies, senior government officials said on Friday. The figures were disclosed at the ‘PM E-DRIVE: Dialogue with the Industry’ event at ICAT in Haryana’s Manesar, presided over by Heavy Industries Minister HD Kumaraswamy, as part of the automotive testing agency’s 20th anniversary.

‘WORK TOGETHER’ Kumaraswamy called for a closer collaboration among testing agencies, vehicle manufacturers, component suppliers, and researchers as India develops new automotive technologies and strengthens its manufacturing capabilities. “We have sanctioned ₹776 crore for upgrading the testing agencies under PM E-DRIVE,” Heavy Industries Additional Secretary Hanif Qureshi said. The investment covers the International Centre for Automotive Technology (ICAT) in Manesar, the Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI) in Pune, the Global Automotive Research Centre (GARC) in Chennai, and the National

CHARGED UP

- Electric two-wheelers accounted for nearly one in every 10 two-wheelers sold in India during April-August 2026
- Heavy Industries Minister HD Kumaraswamy called for a closer collaboration among testing agencies, vehicle manufacturers, component suppliers, and researchers

Automotive Test Tracks (NATRAX) in Indore. It’s aimed at preparing these centre’s for EVs, batteries, clean technologies, and advanced automotive components. With India already the world’s largest producer of two- and three-wheelers, Qureshi said manufacturers and testing agencies need to work together on technologies that can also support exports. “We have to move towards Make in India for the world,” he said.

EV TARGET RAISED PM E-DRIVE’s outlay has been raised to ₹11.90 crore, while incentives for electric two-wheelers have been extended until March 2028. The programme’s target for the segment has nearly doubled to 45.8 lakh vehicles. The ICAT generated a profit of ₹142 crore last year, said Qureshi, citing it as the evidence of the progress made by India’s automotive

testing infrastructure. “When the National Automotive Testing and R&D Infrastructure Project was conceived in 2005, the initial sanction was ₹1,700 crore for three testing centres. It was subsequently enhanced to around ₹3,700 crore,” he said. The objective was to create world-class testing facilities that could support the industry and eventually become self-sustainable.

TRACTOR FACILITIES Kumaraswamy also inaugurated an indigenously developed 100 kN load car, an agricultural-machinery testing facility, and a lift-capacity facility for tractors. “A practical constraint in tractor performance testing was identified and addressed through an in-house engineering solution,” he said. The new facilities are expected to improve testing availability and make certification schedules more predictable.

Ingram Micro steps up India expansion

Our Bureau

US-based technology distributor Ingram Micro has opened more than 500 positions in India this year, as it expands its workforce to tap growing demand across data centres, AI, cybersecurity, cloud and devices. Of the new positions, 70-80 per cent are for the company’s India operations, and the rest for its global capability centre, said Flavio Moraes Junior, Chief Country Executive, Ingram Micro India. “We’re still working for 100 plus [positions].” The company is continuing to hire across business development, sales and pre-sales roles. “We are in the same pace because we are following the country’s opportunity,” said Moraes.

GROWTH ENGINE India is the second-largest market globally for the company. All of its business units in the country are currently growing, he said, including mobility, data centres and cloud. While he did not disclose the growth rates for individual businesses, Moraes said all of them were recording double-digit growth, with some growing faster. The company is also expanding its physical infrastructure. It is moving to a larger warehouse facility in Pune and plans to add more capabilities, including IT asset-disposal services at its Bengaluru warehouse.

Chennai is home to Tesla’s 6th experience centre in India



SALES PUSH. Sharad Agarwal, MD, Tesla India, said the centre will allow customers in Chennai and across Tamil Nadu to order and take vehicle deliveries locally. So far in 2026, the company has seen registrations of nearly 680 cars **BUOY GHOSH**

Our Bureau

Tesla India on Friday opened its sixth experience centre in the country at Express Avenue Mall, Chennai, as the electric-vehicle maker expanded its retail and after-sales presence in Tamil Nadu. This is the company’s sixth centre after Mumbai, Delhi, Gurugram, Bengaluru and Hyderabad. The new centre will allow customers in Chennai and across Tamil Nadu to experience, order and take delivery of Tesla vehicles locally.

CHARGING INFRA “We are very excited that we are coming closer and closer to our customers here in Tamil Nadu and Chennai,” said Sharad Agarwal, India Managing Director, Tesla. Customers ordering in September will be targeted for delivery before Diwali.

Agarwal said Tesla was also expanding its charging infrastructure in India. The company currently has five Supercharging stations with 20 stalls in the country and is expanding home-charging capabilities, too. Agarwal said Tesla’s ownership model was built around software and remote diagnostics, with over 70 per cent of problems that arise potentially solvable remotely. It also offers mobile service with workshop visits required only in extreme cases.

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

RBI cuts time period for export realisation

Mumbai: To further boost dollar inflows, the RBI has reduced the time allowed for exporters to realise export proceeds from 15 months to nine months with effect from October 1The revised time period for realising export proceeds is counted from the date of shipment in case of goods (other than goods exported to a warehouse outside India) and from the date of invoice in case of services. The aforementioned time limit for realising export proceeds is also applicable from the date of sale of goods from the warehouse in case of goods exported to a warehouse outside India. Where the export of goods and services is invoiced or/and settled in rupees, the period for realisation and repatriation of full export value shall be 12 months (against the current 18 months). OUR BUREAU

Forex reserves fall \$14.89 b to \$766 b

New Delhi: The country's forex reserves dropped by \$14.881 billion to \$765.901 billion during the week ended September 18 due to a fall in foreign currency assets, according to RBI data released on Friday. In the previous reporting week, forex reserves had fallen by \$4.924 billion to \$780.782 billion. m

Shishir Sinha

The GST Council's October 7 meeting will focus on process reforms and nothing on rate proposal is expected to be taken up, government sources has said. The Council is meeting after a gap of more than a year. "No rate proposal likely and the entire deliberation will be on process," a highly placed source said. However, the GST Council may also review the 18 per cent GST levied on Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), though the issue is not part of the agenda at present. The possible review comes amid concerns over the impact of MDR on merchants and the overall cost of UPI transactions. One of the key proposals

Cabinet to take up revamped model bilateral investment treaty soon

BALANCING ACT. New framework aims to speed up negotiations, preserve India's judiciary sovereignty

Shishir Sinha

The government is set to overhaul India's model bilateral investment treaty (BIT) framework, with the new text likely to be taken up by the Union Cabinet soon, but taxation and the jurisdiction of domestic courts will remain outside the scope of investor protection provisions, top government sources said. The draft model BIT will allow for international arbitration one year after the exhaustion of local remedies. The current framework requires a foreign investor to wait for five years before initiating a treat-based arbitration against India. That means if a foreign investor has a dispute with India, it should first pursue domestic remedies for five years before bringing a claim under the agreement. There have been a spate of challenges by investors against the five-year clause.

AWAITING CABINET NOD The draft model BIT has been finalised and sent to the Cabinet for approval, a senior government official said. "The draft text of the new

BIT framework has been finalised and sent to the Union Cabinet for approval. It should happen soon," the source said. A key feature of the proposed framework is that India will retain an explicit sovereign right to frame and enforce its tax laws, with tax-related provisions excluded from the treaty. The move assumes significance in the wake of the long-running Vodafone and Cairn tax disputes, in which foreign investors invoked investment treaties to challenge India's retrospective taxation measures before international arbitration tribunals. In 2020, tribunals ruled in favour of Vodafone and Cairn, holding that India's retrospective tax demands breached treaty protections, including the guarantee of fair and equitable treatment. The two cases have become a critical backdrop to India's rethink of its investment treaty regime: the government wants to make the framework more investor-friendly and provide greater certainty to foreign investors, but without allowing BITs to become a route for challenging sovereign taxation decisions.

NOTABLE FEATURES

- The draft model BIT will allow for international arbitration one year after the exhaustion of local remedies
- The current framework requires a foreign investor to wait for five years before initiating a treat-based arbitration against India
- The revamped model BIT is intended to strengthen investor protection
- It also assumes greater importance as Indian companies expand their investments overseas

"No tax-related provisions will be part of the framework as we are not willing to give up on the sovereign right on taxation," government source said. Domestic legal provisions will also not form part of the treaty, as the government intends to keep the judiciary outside the purview of BIT disputes, the source added.

INVESTOR PROTECTION The revamped model BIT is intended to streamline India's treaty negotiations while strengthening investor protection, sources said, although several "red lines" will remain non-negotiable. However, according to Aravind Srivatsan, Senior

Partner and India Tax leader, Nangia Global, the exclusion of taxation from the BIT framework is unlikely to materially alter investor sentiment, particularly since this has been the prevailing approach in India's treaty practice for several years. "Investors are increasingly likely to assess India on its ability to enhance the competitiveness and resilience of their global supply chains and contribute to overall group economics, rather than view tax treatment in isolation. The missing piece in an otherwise compelling investment story is energy security. If India can demonstrate a credible and sustainable pathway towards building a

GST Council meet on Oct 7 to focus on process reforms

Shishir Sinha

expected to receive attention is the protection of genuine buyers from the consequences of tax defaults by their suppliers.

ITC ISSUE There have been lot of litigations and industry has repeatedly raised concerns over the denial of input tax credit (ITC) to recipients when suppliers fail to deposit the tax collected from them. The Council is expected examine the mechanisms to protect eligible taxpayers who have fulfilled their compliance obligations, while ensuring that fraudulent claims are prevented, another source said. One such likely proposal is finalising the guidelines to bring uniformity in documents that are to be submitted for faster processing of GST registration applica-



REVIEW WATCH. The Council is meeting after a gap of more than a year.

tions of businesses who pass on tax credit of over ₹2.5 lakh a month. The guidelines are expected to prescribe norms for cancellation. This will be another big reform after the simplified registration process was initiated last year based on a recommendation by the GST

tax liability does not exceed ₹2.5 lakh per month (inclusive of CGST, SGST/UTGST and IGST), can opt for the scheme. Nearly 65 per cent of the GST registrations are happening through this route. Now, the effort is to bring a simplified mechanism for the remaining 35 per cent, who are basically big businesses.

COMPENSATION CESS There is a big issue about accumulated compensation cess. The matter is now pending in the Supreme Court. A petition filed by the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) challenged the Centre's notifications on transition or refund of accumulated GST compensation cess credit that industry associations have repeatedly estimated to be around ₹2,500 crore in

value. Since the announcement of GST 2.0, auto retailers requested the government to hold significant, validly availed compensation cess balances in their electronic credit ledgers before the new GST regime kicked off on September 22, 2025. Another proposal is likely to be about easing restrictions on ITC for specified goods and services on which credit is currently not available. If recommended, it will benefit motor vehicles and certain other conveyances, food and beverages, outdoor catering, beauty treatment, health services, club memberships and certain travel-related benefits. ITC is also restricted on goods and services used for construction of immovable property, subject to the conditions prescribed under the law. This can also be removed.

India reserves rights to join Russia's CBAM dispute with EU as third party at WTO

Amiti Sen

India is among 18 countries, which includes the UK, the US, China and Brazil, to reserve their third-party rights to participate in the proceedings of Russia's dispute against the EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) package at the WTO. Moscow has alleged that CBAM creates significant trade barriers for covered goods imported into the EU and are inconsistent with WTO obligations. "This will allow India to voice its views on the CBAM levies, which is a big concern to the Indian industry, as third parties receive the primary parties' first written submissions to the panel and are allowed to present their views orally to the panel during the first substantive meeting," a source said. On Friday, the WTO's dispute settlement body (DSB) agreed to establish a panel to examine the EU's CBAM package and alleged export subsidy under the EU scheme for trading greenhouse gas emission allowances at the second request of Russia, per the WTO. Eighteen member countries, including Argentina, Brazil, Canada, China, Chinese Taipei, India, Indonesia, Japan, Saudi Arabia, Korea, Malaysia, Norway, Paraguay, Singapore, Switzerland, Thailand, the UK and the US reserved



New Delhi has raised MSME concerns over the mechanism with the EU, at the WTO and bilaterally

their third-party rights to participate in the proceedings. "Other delegations wishing to reserve their third-party rights have to do so within the next 10 days after this meeting through a written communication," the WTO's DSB noted. While a WTO ruling can't be enforced through penalties without a functioning Appellate Body, an adverse verdict still carries reputational and diplomatic weight for the losing side.

CARBON CHECK The EU's CBAM, which is being phased in right now, calls for exporters of six identified carbon-intensive products, including steel, aluminium and cement, to pay for the embedded carbon emissions

in the form of a levy. Indian exporters, especially those in the MSME sector, have expressed concerns over the compliance burden and the additional costs associated with the mechanism. India has raised the matter with the EU on numerous occasions in various WTO bodies and is also discussing it bilaterally with the bloc. "Well-established principles and rules of both international trade law and international environment law should have been followed in designing the CBAM, including not ignoring the principle of 'common but differentiated responsibilities and respective capabilities,'" India's representative noted at the WTO council for trade in goods meeting in November last year ahead of the phasing in of CBAM levies from January 2026. India is now working with the EU to secure recognition for its national accreditation body, National Accreditation Board for Certification Bodies (NABCB), and local verification agencies. Russia argued at the DSB meeting that the CBAM regime imposes unjustified trade barriers on EU imports and breaches WTO obligations, and that free ETS (emissions trading systems) allowances to select firms in the bloc function as export subsidies propping up domestic competitiveness. The EU maintained that CBAM and emissions trading systems comply with WTO rules.

AAI Chairman transferred to Rural Development Dept

Our Bureau

In a bureaucratic reshuffle, Airports Authority of India (AAI) Chairman Vipin Kumar has been shifted to the Department of Rural Development. Kumar, a 1996-batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer of the Bihar cadre, will now serve as Additional Secretary in the Department of Rural Development as part of a series of senior appointments approved by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC). The order was issued by the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) on Friday. The order does not name his successor at AAI, which comes under the Ministry of Civil Aviation. The ACC also approved the appointment of Director General of Hydrocarbons Srikant Nagulapalli as Additional Secretary in the Department of Expenditure, under the Ministry of Finance. Nagulapalli is a 1998-batch IAS officer of the Andhra Pradesh cadre. The ACC appointed V Ponnuraj, a 2000-batch IAS officer of the Karnataka cadre, as Director General of Hydrocarbons in the rank and pay of Additional Secretary. The ACC approved the appointment of Anand Singh, a 2000-batch IAS officer of the Kerala cadre, as Additional Secretary in the Department of Economic Af-



Vipin Kumar

fairs. In another shift, Sarita Chauhan Chand, Additional Secretary in the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances, has been appointed Additional Secretary and Financial Advisor in the Ministry of Steel. According to the order, P Hemalatha, Development Commissioner of the Cochin Special Economic Zone, will move to the DoPT as Additional Secretary. The ACC has shifted Piyush Singh, Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Power. He has been appointed Mission Director of the National Water Mission under the Ministry of Jal Shakti. Additionally, the order stated that Mandeep K Bhandari has been appointed Chairperson of the Central Board of Secondary Education, while Ankita Mishra Bundela will move from the Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare to the Department of Higher Education as Additional Secretary. The ACC also approved the appointment of Indian Economic Service officer Manisha Sensarma as Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship.

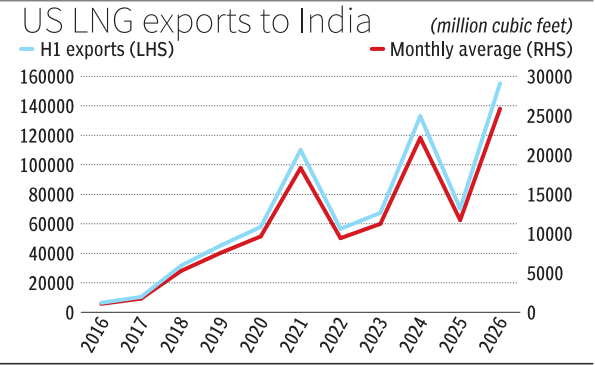
Infra projects see cost overrun of ₹2.88 lakh cr in Aug: MoSPI

Press Trust of India

Infrastructure projects worth more than ₹150 crore each recorded a cumulative cost overrun of around ₹2,88,122 crore, according to a monthly government report for August. A total of 1,731 ongoing infrastructure projects across 17 Central ministries/departments were monitored, and it was found that the total revised cost was ₹33,60,069 crore compared to their original cost of ₹30,71,947 crore. The report, however, did not specify the actual number of projects that faced cost overrun. The cumulative expenditure incurred on these projects stands at ₹16.33 lakh crore, accounting for approximately 48.59 per cent of the revised project cost, indicating steady progress in project implementation, a statement by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation said.

BALANCED PIPELINE A significant proportion of projects are at advanced stages, with 647 projects (38 per cent) achieving over 80 per cent physical progress, while 312 (18 per cent) have crossed 80 per cent financial completion. The data also reflect a balanced pipeline, with projects distributed across early and advanced stages of imple-

India imports record LNG from US in H1



Source: US EIA

Rishi Ranjan Kala

India imported record cargoes of liquefied natural gas (LNG) from the US during January to June in the current calendar year as the West Asia conflict and closure of the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) impacted roughly 50 per cent of its domestic requirement. As per the US EIA, India imported an all-time high 155.25 billion cubic feet (BCF) of LNG from the US in H1 2026, averaging at a record 25.88 BCF per month. Prior to this, India had imported 132.95 BCF in H1 2024, averaging at 22.16 BCF per month. The year 2024 witnessed record LNG cargoes of 256.05 BCF being shipped to India from the US with the 12-month average hitting 21.34 BCF. Analysts and trade sources said that Washington emerged as the key balancing actor in the global LNG market after the West Asia conflict led to closure of the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) effectively choking 20 per cent of the world's LNG supply. The attack on QatarEnergy's Ras Laffan facility has choked almost half of India's LNG consumption as the world's largest LNG liquefaction facility at Ras Laffan operated by QatarEnergy was attacked by Iran in April

leading to wide scale damages. For comparison, about 93 per cent of Qatar's and 96 per cent of the UAE's LNG exports transited through the SoH, representing almost one-fifth of global LNG trade in 2025. There are no alternative routes to bring these volumes to market, said the International Energy Agency (IEA).

TOP SUPPLIER Besides, Washington also emerged as India's largest supplier of LNG during May-July 2026, while imports from Qatar declined 91 per cent year-on-year, said Equirius Securities in a recent commentary. India's LNG import basket has shifted toward US, African and non-Qatari Middle East cargoes, reducing immediate dependence on Qatar, it pointed out. India imported about 7.08 million tonnes (mt) of LNG during the three-month period, up 15 per cent from a year earlier. The US supplied 2.19 mt, followed by Nigeria (1.31 mt), Oman (1.22 mt) and Angola (0.80 mt), while Qatar supplied 0.23 mt. The brokerage noted that LNG berth arrivals remained elevated at 2.4 mt in May and 2.3 mt in June, taking first-quarter FY27 arrivals to 6.2 mt. Provisional July arrivals remained healthy at 2.1 mt, despite elevated spot LNG prices.

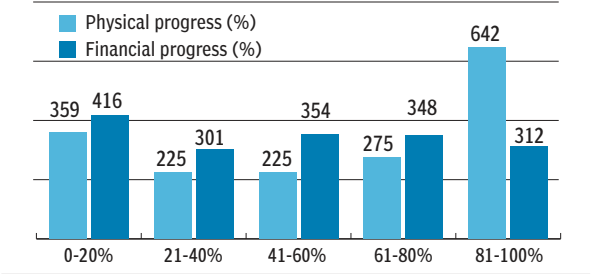
Refiners step up US LPG buying

Bloomberg

State-owned refiners are preparing to boost purchases of US liquefied petroleum gas by more than 25 per cent through annual contracts next year, as Persian Gulf disruptions accelerate the country's push to diversify supplies. Indian Oil Corp, Bharat Petroleum Corp and Hindustan Petroleum Corp are seeking as

many as five 46,000-tonne cargoes a month next year from the US, up from four under 2026 contracts, according to people familiar with the tender. Each shipment must contain equal amounts of propane and butane, they added, asking not to be named as the details are not public. If the agreements are finalised, India's contracted US volumes would rise to about 2.76 mt from 2.2 mt this year.

Project stage



mentation. The Transport & Logistics sector accounts for the highest number of ongoing projects (1,191 projects), with revised estimates of ₹16.05 lakh crore underscoring priority to connectivity-driven infrastructure growth. About 1,731 ongoing infrastructure projects include 715 mega projects (project cost of ₹1,000 crore and above) with an original cost of ₹25.89 lakh crore, and 1,016 major projects (project cost below ₹1,000 crore and up to ₹150 crore), amounting to ₹4.83 lakh crore. Physical and financial progress broadly move in tandem, with a large number of projects clustered at the initial (0-20 per cent) and advanced (81-100 per cent) stages, indicating a pipeline of newly started projects alongside many nearing completion. While physical progress exceeds financial progress in the 81-100 per cent range, financial progress is relatively higher in the early stages, reflecting upfront ex-

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QUICKLY.

Mahindra announces its Thar OG at ₹10.32 lakh



The popular three-door off-roader from Mahindra now gets a revised front end, a new platform (from the Roxx), frequency dependent dampers, an electronic power steering and other updates to its powertrain, tech and feature suite. Prices start at ₹10.32 lakh (ex-showroom) for the base 1.5 AXT RWD (manual) variant, going up to ₹18.99 lakh (all prices, ex-showroom) for the range-topping 2.2 LXT 4x4 variant. In all, the Thar OG is available with two gearboxes and three engine options.

Honda CB500 launched at ₹2.75 lakh in India



Honda's surprise retro single for India, the CB500, has been launched. Featuring a 501 cc single-cylinder air/oil-cooled engine, the CB500 promises old-world thrills in a package that's suitably tech-equipped, too. A slip-and-assist clutch, all-LED lighting, Honda selectable torque control (HSTC) and connectivity via Honda RoadSync are offered as standard. The CB500 is available in three variants, with prices ranging between ₹2.75 lakh (alloy wheels) and ₹3.02 lakh, ex-showroom.

Tata Sierra gets a Dark edition variant



Tata has launched the Sierra Dark edition, primarily a blacked-out cosmetic package. The Sierra Dark edition gets a Friesian Black paint scheme, with a lot of its chrome trim being replaced with black. The alloy wheels and Tata badges are blacked-out, too, along with #Dark badging on the fenders, and this treatment is extended to the cabin as well. Prices start at ₹13.99 lakh (Pure L) going up to ₹21.59 lakh (Accomplished+), ex-showroom.



High Five **E MAJOR.** The BMW i5 eDrive 35L combines an electric powertrain with long-wheelbase luxury. Worth a long look, then?

Ruman Devmane

The i5 isn't a new name to India. In 2024, BMW did give us a flavour of what it could do with an EV sedan, courtesy of the i5 M60, which was less car, more rocket. The i5 you see here isn't the same or anywhere close. This i5 eDrive 35L is a made-in-India long-wheelbase sedan that attempts to package luxury, electric economy and hard-to-ignore pricing to settle its age-old rivalry with the Mercedes-Benz E-Class.

In doing so, the i5, in fact, threatens its own kin. You can have one for ₹79.6 lakh, which makes it exactly ₹3 lakh more expensive than the petrol-engined 530Li M Sport, priced at ₹76.6 lakh. The most affordable E-Class, the E 200 LWB, is priced ₹81.5 lakh (all prices, ex-showroom).

What this will translate to across dealerships is tough to predict — we are in an SUV-dominated market, after all — but what this context-setting exercise indicates is BMW's intent. Cars across classes, however, are sought after for more than mere objectivity. Does the i5 do anything to stir your soul?

It does, but in a very different way to what you'd usually expect from a BMW. The i5 is no purist's dream; BMW would rather you looked elsewhere in its range for driving thrills. The electrified 5 Series has been relieved of that responsibility for its own good. It's a tough one to swallow and yet perfectly rational.

LONG STORY

Let's get to the specifics. In this spec, the i5 measures 5,175 mm in length and features a 3,105 mm wheelbase. That makes it longer than any of its peers, and it sure looks it, too. There's an almost SUV-like stance to it with its near-vertical front end, and the bonnet appears long enough to be able to



AN 'I' FOR DETAIL. The cabin scores high on quality, design and space. The wheels are a 20-inch multi-spoke affair and look great. The rear seats lack recline function but feel extremely plush KARTIK WARE

accommodate a 16-cylinder engine under it. It's a struggle to call it pretty, but it looks striking and impressive, with its tight shut lines, impeccable surface finishes and decided modernity. The sheer expanse of its bodywork makes its 20-inch wheels look just right, a good departure from the 18s on the ICE 5. There isn't enough to tell you it's an EV, though, aside from a tiny 'i' badge integrated into one of the kidney 'grille' elements and an i5 badge on the boot lid. Even the beautiful satin-aluminium garnish at the base of the C-pillar just says '5'.

The interior is beautifully minimalist, firmly upmarket and understated. The twin-curved-screen setup looks modern, and the dif-

fused ambient light strips across the dash and door panels give it a perfectly contemporary edge. The open-pore trim on the dash looks premium, too, and the layered centre console, with its crystal-finish drive selector and dial, looks and feels terrific. Beyond the centre console is a sea of tan leather — could've been darker, perhaps — that's a bit old-school but well-finished nonetheless.

The seats in both row are brilliant, too. The front row is comfortable, with an elaborate backrest and seat base, adjustable to a great degree. There's an ever-so-slight hint of sportiness to them, which bodes well for when (for whatever reason) you're in the mood for an upbeat

drive. The backseat is, of course, where the i5 wants to excel — and it does. This is a sublime backseat, a great place to conduct business or just to stretch out after a hard day at the office. The floor does seat you slightly knees-up, given the battery pack underneath, but it's far from a deal-breaker.

What it lacks is a recline function and a 'boss' mode that lets you push the co-driver's seat away to create extra room, both of which are available on the E-Class. It also misses sun shades (again, present on the E) for the rear windows, which tells you just how stretched BMW was in trying to price the i5 in the way it has. The boot, while spacious by design, features a spare wheel right on the boot floor itself, which means you'll struggle to fit hard luggage — not an ideal car to be chauffeured to the airport in, then. This, by the way, isn't the case with the ICE 5 Series, which features its spare under the boot floor.

ON A CHARGE

That aside, it's comfortably one of the strongest-configured BMWs out there. Featuring an 81.6 kWh battery pack and a single rear-mounted motor, the i5's powertrain produces 268 bhp and 41.8 kg-m, good enough to keep its performance nearly level with its petrol counterpart. The claimed range is 669 km, although under a mixed driving cycle and drawing from the indicated data from our short stint with it, a real-world range of 450 km or so should be possible. With DC fast charging (capable of up to 160 kW), you can charge it from 10-80 per cent in 33 minutes (claimed), which is really impressive for its use case.

To drive, the i5 is a surprise package. Okay, it's no pocket rocket, but having evolved from the textbook definition of what a 5 Series had to be, its spiritedness is rather stately. In 'Sport' mode, the i5 can produce strong acceleration all the way to its 195-kph limited top speed, but you'll rarely want to drive it in that

frame of mind. Here's a BMW that offers brilliant real-world performance; overtakes are quick and easy, and you'll take off from traffic lights (or toll gates) with agility. It isn't, however, a driver's car and that's probably all right. The steering, for one, is too light — great for city driving — but bears no resemblance to anything its lineage represents. I wish it had some heft, even if electronically induced, because it's slightly tricky to judge at really high speeds.

Where BMW shows its strengths, especially as a formidable EV maker, is in the calibration of everything. The throttle, for one, is clearly the new benchmark in how connected and communicative it feels. Yes, the inherent silence is a dead giveaway of the i5 being an EV, but to drive it feels no different from driving an ICE car. It takes virtually no time at all to adapt to its mannerisms, and, especially thanks to the four regen levels (Low, Mid, High and Adaptive), you can drive the i5 in a way you wouldn't expect to drive a car of its dimensions. There's a 'B' mode, too, which is its done-to-perfection single-pedal driving mode.

What you'll love about it, regardless of whether you choose to drive or be chauffeured, is its ride quality. You'd think a heavy, low-slung sedan with 20-inch wheels would come with compromises, but the i5 is just phenomenal in its ability to soak up road undulations. Ground clearance is surprisingly good, too, and even the trickiest of speed breakers posed no challenge for it. This, along with a well-insulated cabin, translates to a 5 Series-like experience unlike any before it.

At ₹79.6 lakh, the i5 goes beyond just compelling. Provided its feature omissions don't matter to you, the i5 sets a solid standard for what you can expect from a luxury sedan. As an EV, it has capabilities rather than limitations, and it works brilliantly as a modern, large and plush machine. Take a bow, BMW!

@TheMotorGram



Less is More

LIGHT WORK. The Pulsar 125 combines agility and lightness with energetic performance. Sounds like your next sporty commuter, then?



VALUE DEAL. The new 124.5 cc engine is buzzy but punchy and characterful. TFT instrumentation does the job. The seat is spacious and comfortable; the monoshock is a great addition PRASHANT SHETTY

Ruman Devmane

The new Bajaj Pulsar 125 is exactly what you don't think it is. It may, by design, be the smallest and slowest, but allow me to declare, it's as much a Pulsar as some of the best out there if not more. It has a straightforward job at hand — to bring a Pulsar (fun) flavour to commuting, that is — but armed with new-generation underpinnings and tech, it goes beyond.

So much beyond, in fact, that it somewhat steps on the toes of the

Pulsar NS125 as well. While the new 125's 11.9 bhp and 1.16 kg-m may be only nominally higher than the NS 125's output tally, the former is 13 kg lighter!

Sure, the NS gets far more substantial rubber and a perimeter frame, but it will take a sizable update for hierarchy within the family to be restored. Bajaj rarely flinches in the face of cannibalisation and in any case, if the Pulsar 125 is gunning for something, it's the 150!

Having extensively ridden both in immediate succession, I was delighted to find the Pulsar 125

more thrilling than the 150. It's less powerful and, therefore, slower but only nominally so.

FUN INTENDED

Bajaj's own numbers reveal the 125 goes from 0-60 kph in 6.4 seconds and hits a top speed of 99 kph — that's a 0.7-second and 7-kph deficit to the 150. The secret, I suppose, is in its 10-kg advantage (131-kg kerb weight; the 150 weighs 141 kg). Would you favour a slim performance advantage over ₹19,000 (or ₹30,000, if you consider the lowest spec 125 with a 240-mm disc) of your hard-

earned money? Oh, this is going to be a fun watch! Before I get carried away, though, I must clarify that the 125 and 150 are almost entirely different in demeanour, in that the latter is far more refined and grown-up.

That is also just why the 125 feels so much more fun! I rode one right after the 150, expecting reasonably less, and was instantly surprised. The 125 is a quick, responsive and rather agile motorcycle that loves every aggressive input you might throw at it. The engine sounds the way you'd expect a Pulsar to (busy) and in the

city it's an absolute hoot with the way it accelerates across its rev range. Sure, it gets buzzy as you push it harder, but for how smile-inducing its performance is, you'd probably forgive it that.

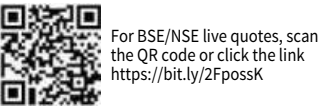
SHARP SHOOTER

Its performance felt encouraging enough for me to venture onto the highway with it where it, amazingly, didn't feel like a let-down at all. It nearly kept pace with a Pulsar 150 leading the way — even as the 150 rider may have been experiencing far fewer vibes — and that should tell you some-

thing about the 125's performance. The gearshifts, too, are refined, but not without a mechanical feel to them, which is good. What tops that is the Pulsar 125's chassis. This new tubular-steel frame lends the Pulsar so much poise and agility that it nearly makes you look past power figures and the resultant performance. You can produce serious dramatic lean angles on it or just get creative through slow-moving traffic. The brakes, too, felt well-suited to the job, and the tyres held up admirably in dry conditions. What sweetens the

Pulsar 125 story is its high degree of comfort. It's roomy, ergonomically sound and the single-piece seat (there are two higher-priced split-seat variants as well) felt sporty enough while still being comfortable. So, it's a no-brainer, then? Almost, but that's only if you've ruled out the quicker, lighter and cheaper TVS Raider. If you have indeed, the Pulsar 125, priced between ₹92,990 and ₹1.04 lakh (ex-showroom) is the best motorcycle of its kind you can get your hands on.

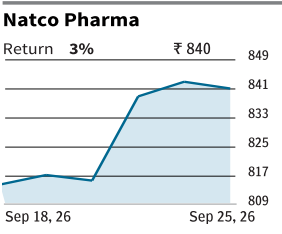
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QUICKLY.

Natco Pharma approves ₹1,279 crore rights issue



New Delhi: Drugmaker Natco Pharma on Friday said its board of directors has approved the issuance of shares through a rights issue to raise up to ₹1,279.35 crore. According to a regulatory filing, the company will issue up to 1.71 crore shares of face value of ₹2 each at an issue price of ₹750 per share to raise an amount not exceeding ₹1,279.35 crore. The rights issue has been approved at the entitlement ratio of 2 rights shares for every 21 fully paid-up shares held by eligible shareholders as on the record date, which has been fixed as October 1. The rights issue is scheduled to open on October 12 and close on October 22. **■**

Adani Group entities swap 86 lakh Adani Ent shares

New Delhi: Around 86 lakh shares changed hands between the promoter group entities of the Adani Group's flagship firm Adani Enterprises in a deal worth ₹2,498 crore through separate block deals on Friday. The shares, representing a 0.63 per cent stake in the Ahmedabad-based conglomerate, were picked up by Adani Infra (India) and Adani Properties, according to data on the NSE. Adani Properties bought 51.5 lakh shares, while Adani Infra (India) acquired 34.5 lakh shares in the Group's flagship company. The shares changed hands at an average price of ₹2,905. On the other side of the trades, promoter group entity Infinite Trade And Investment sold an equal number of shares at the same price, the data showed. **■**

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Target: ₹6,150
CMP: ₹4,719.75
SPR Auto Technologies (SPR) is evolving from being a traditional piston manufacturer into a diversified, technology-driven, powertrain-agnostic mobility platform through strategic inorganic acquisitions. The piston business is a strong cash-cow franchise for SPR, supported by market leadership, -500 bp higher margins than the next peer and core RoCE of over 50 per cent. SPR is benefiting from rising multi-fuel opportunities (CNG, ethanol, hydrogen and hybrids), strong aftermarket demand, and the premature exit of global competitors from the ICE ecosystem. Leveraging its strong balance sheet and cashflow profile, SPR is reinvesting in acquisitions such as Antolin, Takahata, TGPEL and EMFI, thereby diversifying beyond powertrain-focused products to precision plastic molding components and expanding estimated content per vehicle by 6x to over ₹30,000. This strategy helps SPR create a scalable auto component platform with balanced exposure across powertrains. Additionally, the company has recently completed the ₹10 billion QIP to fund future organic and inorganic growth opportunities, which could act as a key trigger for further upside. We initiate coverage with a Buy rating and a TP of ₹6,150, premised on 30x Sep'28E EPS.
Key risks: Rise in competitive intensity, fluctuations in commodity prices, changes in technology and loss of key customers.

Emkay Global

DR LAL PATHLABS (BUY)
Target: ₹2,100
CMP: ₹1,951.85
Dr Lal Pathlabs (DLPL) has announced the acquisition of SN Genelab — a B2B diagnostics operator focused on advanced genomics and molecular pathology testing — for ₹168 crore (70 per cent stake), thus valuing the company at around 16x FY26 EV/EBITDA. We expect the company to cross-sell SN Genelab's test offerings on its wider platform (both B2B and B2C channels) and expect revenue synergies to accrue in the next 2-3 years. Per management, this acquisition allows for deepening DLPL's specialized testing portfolio as well as enabling geographical diversification of the revenue base (West region contributed 14 per cent to FY26 revenue). We find the valuation for this acquisition reasonable, given the strong financials and profitable growth demonstrated by SN Genelab. DLPL's leadership position and execution prowess position it to benefit from the current industry tailwinds (stable pricing environment, shift toward quality organised operators, and increasing adoption of preventive testing). We expect revenue/EBITDA CAGR of 15/16 per cent over FY26-29 (ex-acquisition) and retain Buy.
We raise our Sep-27E TP by 5 per cent to ₹2,100 from ₹2,000 (based on DCF method), implying FY28E PER of 48x (in line with LTA).
Key risks: Irrational pricing environment, inflationary pressures owing to ME crisis, and disruption in the raw-material supply chain.

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NSE open to self-listing if SEBI allows, looks beyond options for revenues

KEY AREAS. Data monetisation, tech solutions, connectivity and new products could be growth drivers: Chairman

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The National Stock Exchange of India has indicated that it remains open to listing its own shares on its trading platform in the future, provided the Securities and Exchange Board of India is satisfied that potential conflicts of interest can be adequately addressed. Speaking after the NSE's recent stock market debut, Chairman Srinivas Injeti said: "Self-listing may not be permitted today, but may be permitted tomorrow."

He said the possibility remains "in the realm of feasibility" and would ultimately depend on SEBI's assessment of conflict-of-interest concerns.

The comments come at a time when investors are closely examining whether the NSE can sustain its strong earnings trajectory, particularly given its reliance on transaction-linked revenues and index options trading.

REVENUE MATRIX

Injeti said transaction-based income continued to be the exchange's primary revenue source, although non-transaction businesses have steadily expanded over time. Currently, around 80 per cent of revenues are linked to trading activity, and the rest comes from other streams. The NSE aims to gradually diversify this mix over the medium to long term. "By nature, an exchange will largely depend



DIVERSIFICATION. Srinivas Injeti, Chairman, NSE, said the dependence on weekly index options had moderated sharply **■**

upon volumes and trading activity," Injeti said, adding that data monetisation, technology solutions, connectivity services and new products could emerge as significant growth drivers.

However, the exchange stressed that its dependence on weekly index options had moderated significantly from earlier levels, when the

segment accounted for nearly 75-80 per cent of revenues.

The NSE also expects its commodities segment to play a larger role in the coming years as liquidity deepens. Sriram Krishnan, Chief Business Development Officer, NSE, said crude oil options were currently generating a premium turnover of

₹10,000-15,000 crore every month, with substantial scope for growth as participation increases. Alongside commodities, the NSE plans to leverage its proprietary technology platforms and expand higher-margin businesses, such as market data and connectivity services.

IPO PRICING

Responding to questions over the stock's muted post-listing performance, Injeti said the IPO pricing was calibrated to balance the interests of investors and selling shareholders.

He said the exchange intentionally left some value on the table for investors, while noting that short-term stock performance would also be influenced by broader market conditions.

PAYING TRIBUTE



REMEMBERING THE FOUNDER. On the occasion of NSE's listing, Ashishkumar Chauhan, MD & CEO, felicitated Sunanda Ramchandra Patil, wife of NSE founding member late Dr RH Patil. The moment was a tribute to the visionary who laid the foundation of the NSE and shaped its journey as a capital market infrastructure of national importance **■**

Nifty posts 7th straight weekly loss on macro headwinds

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The benchmarks clawed back some ground on Friday after Thursday's sharp sell-off, though the recovery was narrow and tentative as a clutch of macro headwinds, elevated crude oil prices, high US bond yields and persistent foreign fund outflows, continued to weigh on sentiment.

The Nifty 50 closed at 23,140.50, up 0.34 per cent, and the Sensex at 73,895.74, higher by 0.43 per cent.

For the week, however, the Nifty fell 0.88 per cent, its seventh consecutive weekly decline, and has now shed over 1,750 points from its early-August peak of 24,772.

Friday's session was defined as much by what didn't happen as what did. Brent crude, despite easing around 1.2 per cent to \$105.3 a barrel, remained well above \$100. WTI held in the \$92-

\$93 range. The US 10-year Treasury yield remained near 5.2 per cent, close to its highest level since 2007, keeping up the pressure on global risk appetite.

"Volatile crude and bond yields at elevated levels kept the market recovery capped," said Vinod Nair, Head of Research at Geojit Investments Ltd. "Improving valuations and resilient domestic growth prospects are encouraging selective accumulation, helping the market absorb external pressures more effectively."

Sectorally, Auto, Realty and Consumer Durables led the advance, while IT and Healthcare remained subdued. Broader markets were mixed, the Nifty Midcap 100 slipped 0.14 per cent, while the Nifty Smallcap 100 managed a 0.15 per cent gain.

The India VIX eased 3.4 per cent to 12.13, signalling some moderation in near-term anxiety following Thursday's sharp sell-off.

JSW One Platforms moves SEBI for ₹3,054-crore IPO

Our Bureau
Chennai

JSW One Platforms, a B2B commerce player promoted by the JSW Group and backed by Mitsui, has filed a draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with the SEBI for a ₹3,054-crore IPO. The offer comprises a fresh issue worth ₹1,300 crore and an offer-for-sale of ₹1,754 crore. JSW Steel, JSW Cement and Mitsui & Co will offload part of their stake through the OFS window in the IPO.

The company proposes to utilise the net proceeds towards investment in JSW One Distribution Ltd (JODL) for marketing and

brand-building expenditure, technology and platform development expenditure, investment in JSW One Finance (JOFL) to augment its capital base and general corporate purposes. Besides, ₹125 crore will be invested in JODL and ₹500 crore in JOFL, while up to ₹350 crore is proposed towards technology and platform development.

JSW One Platforms operates an integrated digital platform connecting MSMEs with sellers of manufacturing and construction materials, while bringing together commerce, embedded financing, logistics, processing and customisation and private brands.

German Green Steel, Orient Cables IPOs shine; 2 others see modest interest

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Friday saw four companies tapping the capital market with initial public offerings (IPOs) that saw robust-to-moderate interest.

Among them, the issues from German Green Steel and Orient Cables (India) were fully subscribed on day 1 itself, while Runwal Enterprises and Ace Vector saw a modest response.

Ahead of the IPOs, Runwal Enterprises and German Green Steel and Power raised ₹149 crore and ₹91 crore from anchor investors; AceVector, the parent company of Snapdeal, Unicommerce and Stellaro Brands,

raised ₹189 crore, and Orient Cables mopped up ₹165.6 crore.

Runwal Enterprises, the real estate firm, allocated 48,83,605 shares at ₹305 a share to anchor investors. It fixed the price band at ₹290-305 for its ₹500-crore entirely fresh issue. From the proceeds, it will use ₹100 crore for repayment of debt and invest ₹225 crore in wholly owned subsidiaries for repayment of borrowing, funding acquisitions for future real estate projects and general corporate purposes.

At the end of day 1, the IPO was subscribed 0.42 times.

GERMAN GREEN STEEL

German Green Steel and

Power garnered ₹91 crore from anchor investors.

Some of them included Necta Bloom VCC – Necta Bloom One, Lords Multigrowth Fund, Compact Structure Fund, Arnesta Global Opportunities Fund PCC – Arnesta Global Fund 1, Zeal Global Opportunities Fund and Venus Investments Fund – Venus Stellar Fund.

German Green Steel and Power Ltd fixed the price band of ₹132-139 a share. The IPO consists of a fresh issue of ₹290 crore and an OFS of up to 10 lakh shares by promoters. The IPO was subscribed 1.73 times.

The IPO of Oriental Cables was subscribed 1.96 times while that of Ace Vector 0.23 times.

SEBI bans Omaxe, 5 others for violating shareholding norms

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

SEBI has barred realty firm Omaxe and five others from accessing the securities market for up to one year and imposed a fine totalling ₹1.92 crore for allegedly creating an artificial public shareholding structure to meet the minimum public shareholding requirements.

Omaxe has been re-strained from accessing the securities market for three months, while promoters Rohtas Goel and Jai Bhagwan Goel and group companies — Dream Home Developers Pvt Ltd and Guild Builders Pvt Ltd — have been barred for one year. Sunil Goel, former Joint Managing Director of Omaxe, has also been prohibited from the securities market for one year, the order noted.

SEBI said Omaxe failed to achieve the prescribed 25 per cent minimum public shareholding through independent public shareholders, as certain entities had acquired the company's shares using funds originating from Omaxe and its group entities.

The regulator said that funds originating from Omaxe and group entities were routed through multiple entities and used to acquire its shares in the names of entities shown as public shareholders.

Also, the regulator imposed a fine of ₹1.92 crore on them.

RINGSIDE VIEW.

KS BADRI NARAYANAN

Welcome Abakkus Asset Manager Ltd to the capital markets in yet another avatar. The Sunil Banwarilal Singhania-promoted fund house recently filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) with capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for its initial public offering (IPO). The IPO is primarily aimed at enabling the company to list its equity shares on the stock exchanges, the fund house said in a release.

As of August end, the fund house is managing assets under management of ₹52,609 crore.

According to an ICRA report cited in the DRHP, Abakkus is among the fastest-growing India-focused asset management platforms in terms of non-mutual fund quarterly average assets under management (QAUM). Its non-mutual fund QAUM grew at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 18.39 per cent between FY24 and FY26.

A SLEW OF IPOs

This is the second fund house to enter the IPO market after industry leader SBI Funds Management, which launched its public issue in July, raising ₹9,813 crore.

In July, SBI Funds Management, India's largest asset management company with AUM exceeding ₹12 lakh crore, launched its ₹9,813-crore IPO and successfully listed its shares.

Earlier, the Canara Bank-owned Canara Robeco AMC also tapped the capital markets and listed successfully last year.

Nippon India Mutual Fund (formerly Reliance Mutual Fund, which earlier acquired Goldman Sachs' India AMC business) was the first asset management company in India to tap the capital markets, raising ₹1,540 crore through its IPO at an issue price of ₹252. If Abakkus lists its shares, it would be the 10th company from the AMC space to enter the listed space directly.

Currently there are 60 AMCs, per SEBI data. They manage over ₹87 lakh crore in assets under management (AUM) as of end-August, according to the Association of Mutual Funds in India. MF assets have been growing at



STRONG GROWTH. Mutual funds managed over ₹87 lakh crore in assets under management at the end of August 2026, witnessing a steady climb over a period

18-19 per cent CAGR since FY21. During the same period, the unique investor count in the industry has grown from 5.36 crore to 6.14 crore. Monthly systematic investment plan (SIP) inflows rose to record ₹32,297 crore.

SURGING SIPs

One of the major reasons behind the interest in MFs is household investments shifting from banks to the MF industry.

"The share of mutual funds in gross flow of annual household savings rose from 3 per cent in 2020 to 13 per cent in 2025, signalling a structural shift in how savings are being intermedi-

ated," said Crisil Intelligence. Rapid digitalisation, higher financial literacy and a preference for systematic investment plans (SIPs) drove this growth, highlighting a shift in investor preferences towards diversified and high-growth investment avenues, the study highlighted.

The buoyancy in the mutual fund industry has also found its way into the stock market, with several listed AMCs delivering stellar returns. Nippon AMC, for instance, has surged 165 per cent over the past five years, far outpacing the Nifty's 40 per cent gain. Over three years, it has risen 46 per cent, nearly three times the

benchmark's 13 per cent return. ICICI Prudential and HDFC AMC have also beaten the Nifty, while UTI Mutual Fund has outperformed the benchmark over the past year. In contrast, SBI Funds Management and Canara Robeco Mutual Fund continue to trade below their IPO prices.

Going ahead, the mutual fund space is expected to remain vibrant, with India's relatively low MF penetration at around 20 per cent of the GDP, leaving ample room for growth, particularly when compared with developed markets.

However, with more players entering the fray, the AMC space is getting increasingly crowded — not just with fund houses, but also with PMS providers. In this competitive landscape, the ability to innovate — both in products and marketing — will be key to standing out and driving growth.

Besides, regulatory changes will remain a key factor to watch closely. Fund houses will need to navigate these challenges while continuing to cater to the growing pool of investors who are increasingly turning to mutual funds over traditional savings avenues.

Nifty 50 Movers

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Axis Bank	1222.40	22.53	13.61	3.32
HDFC Bank	735.60	22.42	13.73	10.64
M&M	3035.00	10.20	18.64	2.56
Reliance Ind	1226.00	10.94	18.82	7.82
Bajaj Finance	996.90	8.73	30.06	2.52
Asian Paints	2444.00	5.07	48.46	1.04
Titan	4884.00	4.65	75.28	1.90
L&T	3876.20	4.55	27.17	4.28
State Bank	983.00	4.06	10.12	3.84
HCL Tech	1258.00	3.32	19.58	2.15
PowerGrid Corp	269.50	3.07	15.77	1.15
UltraTech Cement	11155.00	2.56	38.35	1.25
Int'lGlobeAvi	4940.00	2.47	0.00	1.06
Coal India	426.10	2.15	8.42	0.96
Maruti Suzuki	12065.00	2.14	26.46	1.49
ITC	269.00	2.11	16.70	2.45
Grochim Ind	3191.00	2.02	19.08	1.14
Hind Unilever	1942.90	1.82	43.50	1.63
NestleIndia	1362.60	1.82	68.94	0.92
Bajaj Auto	11281.00	1.77	27.29	1.18
Shriram Finance Ltd.	994.10	1.25	20.67	1.31
Bharat Elec	393.55	1.21	46.79	1.33
Bajaj Finserv	1711.00	1.16	13.14	0.97
Adani Ports	2916.50	1.04	50.50	0.79
HDFC Life	531.00	0.96	58.01	0.54
JSW Steel	1277.00	0.78	11.16	1.13
Tech Mahindra	1548.00	0.69	29.38	0.93
Eicher Motors	7360.00	0.65	35.00	0.96
Sun Pharma	1852.20	0.53	36.68	1.85
Adani Ports	1718.00	0.44	31.40	1.25
Wipro	164.02	0.22	12.23	0.42
Cipla	1399.70	0.09	33.70	0.74
Dr Reddys Lab	1201.00	0.08	31.49	0.69
Apollo Hosp	8889.00	0.01	58.84	0.86
NTPC	326.60	0.00	11.18	1.46
Tata Steel	187.97	-0.02	20.84	1.35
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	227.00	-0.14	72.53	0.70
TataConsumerProduct	983.20	-0.44	59.25	0.60
Eternal Ltd.	335.00	-0.79	746.62	2.29
TCS	2082.00	-1.12	15.05	2.01
SBI Life	1742.00	-1.28	67.19	0.74
Hindalco	977.00	-1.58	13.39	1.34
Kotak Bank	404.00	-1.61	19.80	2.81
Tata Motors PV	290.45	-2.08	0.00	0.57
Trent Ltd.	2669.30	-2.23	78.44	0.84
ONGC	235.86	-2.67	6.62	0.87
Max Healthcare	1014.00	-5.20	67.71	0.71
Bharti Airtel	1785.40	-6.31	29.88	5.13
Infosys	1000.20	-10.96	13.38	3.31
ICICI Bank	1326.80	-12.05	15.93	8.98

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Tvs Motor Cmp .	4157.30	45.26	54.85	3.95
SamvardhanothersInternat	165.71	41.21	38.40	2.96
Adani Power .	202.75	39.43	26.90	3.41
Tata Motors Cy	441.50	26.36	38.83	3.73
Torrent Pharma	4988.50	25.58	88.01	2.96
Siemens Energy India .	3313.00	25.08	79.29	1.19
Difl	683.00	23.49	38.03	1.77
Hyundai Motor India .	2115.00	22.54	34.71	1.22
AvenueSuper	3834.20	21.87	81.79	2.50
Tata Power .	22520.00	19.63	23.24	2.48
Solar Industries	19745.00	18.76	87.14	1.35
Zyduslisciences	1203.90	17.16	26.38	1.22
Rural Elec	312.95	17.06	5.14	1.58
AdaniGreenenergy	1296.60	16.08	99.52	1.76
Britannia Ind	4937.50	14.55	45.56	2.35
Hindustanaeronautics	4800.00	14.22	34.44	3.69
Varun Beverages .	434.80	14.11	43.14	2.41
Bosch	48250.00	12.60	60.22	1.69
Ltmitndtree	4083.00	12.15	23.31	1.54
Siemens	3877.00	9.04	95.04	1.39
Bpcl	308.50	8.25	7.81	2.53
Jindal Steel	1164.80	7.54	43.87	1.75
Shree Cement	22520.00	6.61	49.66	1.22
Divs Lab	9619.50	6.46	87.31	4.95
Godrej Consumer	880.00	5.84	47.06	1.43
Macrotech Developers .	1165.00	5.64	28.19	1.31
Bank Of Baroda	235.26	5.18	6.61	1.77
Tata Capital	339.15	4.24	26.28	0.69
Union Bank	180.20	4.21	6.66	1.41
MuthootFin	2635.00	3.02	9.38	1.23
Bajaj Holdings	10940.00	2.89	13.54	1.92
Hindus Zinc	588.95	2.52	14.58	1.15
Indian Railway Finance Corp	79.95	0.53	14.53	0.65
United Spirits .	1423.80	0.43	61.39	1.70
Magagan Dock	2199.60	-0.53	31.09	0.68
Amruba Cements	2613.00	-0.56	36.10	1.59
Hdfc Amc	2378.00	-1.36	34.58	1.96
Cg Power & Ind Sol	886.00	-1.39	112.70	2.46
Adani Energy Solutions .	1338.50	-1.91	52.03	1.78
Pidilind	157.20	-4.32	57.70	1.90
Adani Hotels Co. .	716.80	-5.10	44.81	2.58
Punjab Natl Bank	116.60	-5.60	6.03	1.63
Vedanta	260.50	-5.27	62.04	2.94
Power Finance	338.00	-5.71	33.2	1.99
Indian Oilcorp	135.70	-6.19	5.36	2.05
Canara Bank	124.99	-8.89	5.72	1.70
Gul India	172.70	-9.01	11.50	1.89
Cammins India	494.50	-10.99	57.91	2.70
Cholam	705.20	-11.67	96.10	1.50
Abdindalamini&Fin	1662.70	-23.89	24.65	2.91

Icon among icons

Warren Buffett's retirement marks end of an era

Nature abhors a vacuum, but the world is about to discover that some voids are genuinely impossible to fill. The void created by the investing stalwart Warren Buffett when he hung up his boots as Chairman of Berkshire Hathaway last week is one such. Just as in cricket, where any batting great in the last three-quarters of a century could at best earn the moniker ‘the best after Bradman’, so could be the case in the investing world from here on.



While Buffett's shareholders reaped the returns, and beneficiaries globally gained from his gigantic charitable initiatives, a posterity of investors can reap success from his wisdom. Buffett's greatness is not just about the fact that an investor who backed him and bought shares of Berkshire Hathaway when he took over in May 1965 would be around 120 times wealthier today compared to the S&P 500. It is as much about the fact that in an investing career that has spanned nine decades (he started investing at the age of 11), 96-year old Buffett's rare record spans not just performance, but longevity combined with consistency and a remarkable lack of controversy. In fact, it was his reputation and goodwill that saved the large investment bank Salomon Brothers from annihilation after it got embroiled in the Treasury bond market-rigging controversy in 1991. Faced with a complete ban from the US Treasury markets that would have forced it into bankruptcy, Buffett, as the largest shareholder, took over as interim Chairman and turned things around. His famous message at that time to the employees of the bank to be uncompromising on ethics with the words, “lose money for the firm, and I will be understanding; lose a shred of reputation for the firm, and I will be ruthless“, still ring strong.

He made it clear through his life's work that being an investing genius is 1 per cent knowledge and 99 per cent discipline. It is the discipline to never invest without providing for an adequate “margin of safety” (a phrase he considered the three most important words in investing); to stay within one's circle of competence by investing only in what you understand — and to plan for adversity. There were eight recessions and countless stock market crashes during his 61 years at the helm, yet not once was he caught on the wrong foot. Berkshire Hathaway was always positioned to capture the best bargains during crises — situations that Buffett termed as ‘times when they will be the only persons willing to act’.

As for knowledge, when students in an investing class once asked him how to prepare for a career, he recommended reading “500 pages like this every day,” referring to a stack of financial manuals. That knowledge is clearly affirmed by the troves of investment logic laid bare in his annual letters to shareholders over the last six decades. Spanning multiple market cycles, economic shifts, geopolitical crises, and technological disruptions, these letters serve as a treasure trove of guidance. As he hangs up his boots, he will be regarded as the icon among icons in the investing world.

POCKET



Prioritise insurance distribution reforms

PROTECTION GAP. Skewed commission payouts, lack of push into underserved markets are among issues that need to be addressed



TC SUSEEL KUMAR
R SUDHAKAR

IRDAI published its much-awaited consultation paper on distribution reforms on September 23, and the draft paper is open for comments till October 25. The consultation paper deserves appreciation for covering a wide range of relevant issues, keeping the customer at the centre, and proposing a few much-needed changes. The candid admission that “Reforms of 2023 have not achieved their dual objective of enhancing customer benefits and improving insurance penetration” is an admirable stand, rarely seen in the public space. The draft paper covers many distinct areas, and our analysis is focused more on the life insurance distribution perspective.

A table in the draft paper shows what life insurers paid each channel as commission on first-year premium in FY25. Individual agents took home 27 per cent on average and 34 per cent at the highest. Banks received 27 per cent on average and up to 62 per cent. Brokers averaged 43 per cent, going up to 92 per cent. Corporate agents other than banks and NBFCs received 61 per cent on average and up to 92 per cent at the top end. The paper deserves credit for its transparency in channel-wise costs, and its diagnosis is sound.

From the regulator's own figures, it is evident that the individual agent was among the least expensive channels for new business. To earn the 27 per cent average, the agent has to build the confidence of the prospect in the company and help select the best-suited product. She has to make multiple visits, face rejection more often than obtain consent, and, undeterred, still plough on to take the message of life insurance across the nation. She follows up every

instalment, assists with policy loans, revivals and ultimately stands by the beneficiary during the claim process. The effort put in by the individual agent throughout the life of the policy is far higher than that of institutional channels which possess superior infrastructure, adequate manpower and direct access to affluent client bases.

IRDAI frankly admits that its 2023 decision to remove commission caps and rely on board-approved policies has not met its dual objectives, and proposes justified hard, all-inclusive caps. The paper observes that remuneration is driven more by competition for distribution relationships than by actual solicitation effort. The paper rightly recognises that agents tied to one insurer should earn more than multi-tied distributors, proposing 25 per cent for agents against 20 per cent for entities such as banks on long-term policies.

However, the difference in ground effort is far larger than this gap suggests. A relook and a meaningful increase in the cap for individual agents would be a welcome step. While the intent to reduce acquisition costs and enhance customer value is understandable, the individual agent is the wrong place to look for a larger saving.

NEW MARKETS, NEW LIVES
The present distribution architecture tends to favour readily accessible urban and salaried customers over underserved markets. The additional commission incentives proposed for rural and small-town businesses are welcome. We propose one further enhancement: an additional 10 per cent over the applicable first-year limit for

The present distribution architecture tends to favour readily accessible urban and salaried customers over underserved markets

any policy issued to a life taking their first-ever life insurance policy. The Public Insurance Registry (PIR), once operational, can verify this. Until then, insurers can rely on the proposal form declarations and Insurance Information Bureau (IIB) records. The regulator's primary concern is that premium volume has grown without a matching increase in the number of insured lives; this addition directly targets that structural gap.

SEGREGATION OF EXPENSES
What counts as commission needs proper accounting segregation. While sales campaign cash rewards should fall within commission caps, benefits like gratuity, group term life, and health cover represent essential social security for self-employed workers and should stay outside the cap.

Benefits tied to long service, sustained performance, high persistency, and shared office expenses (such as premium collection and local servicing support) should be categorised as operating expenses. They fund services that the insurer would otherwise have to undertake through its own branch network. Mandatory agency development costs must similarly be excluded from direct commission caps. The proposed Expenses of Management (EoM) audit will adequately safeguard against potential accounting anomalies if any.

The consultation paper proposes raising the minimum educational qualification for new agents from Class 10 to Class 12. In the same document, IRDAI emphasises that insurance penetration cannot expand without a larger agency force. These two goals pull in opposite directions. Many prospective agents in rural regions have completed education up to Class 10. Raising the barrier will disproportionately hurt coverage in regions where expansion is needed most. Professional quality can be better ensured through higher pass marks in qualifying examinations and improved

training rather than a Class 12 certificate.

REWARDING GOOD CONDUCT
The existing remuneration framework fails to differentiate between distributors providing long-term customer service and those focused solely on short-term acquisition. Customer retention, quality of advice, servicing standards, and favourable claim experience receive little financial recognition. These must be systematically valued and rewarded. The paper's measures for market conduct are commendable: linking commissions to effort and complexity, offering higher renewal commissions for long-term policy persistency, curbing dark patterns, reducing mis-selling, and restricting compulsory product bundling. These initiatives should ultimately deliver lower net costs, improved customer retention, operational transparency, effective post-sales service, and overall long-term value for policyholders.

Insurance continues to grow, but at a pace that remains inadequate relative to the size and needs of India's fast-growing economy. Penetration is still low and the protection gap remains alarmingly high. India's insurance story will ultimately be written in living rooms where an agent sits down, asks the uncomfortable questions, and waits for a “yes” that may take half a dozen unwelcome visits. Break the incentive, and we break the primary bridge delivering protection to young families before risk materialises. Let us refine the framework thoughtfully, meaningfully and gradually, encourage good conduct, align industry standards, bring in increased customer value and deliver on the core promise of insurance: affordable, broad, and present when it matters most. That is how we achieve Insurance for All by 2047.

Suseel is a former Managing Director and Sudhakar is a former Executive Director, LIC. Views are personal. Data is taken from the relevant IRDAI consultation paper

Create the right digital ecosystem for children

While enhancing online safety, opportunities to learn, connect and develop digital capabilities must be preserved

Dibyasree Ganguly
Garima Agarwal

The debate over children's access to social media has entered a new phase worldwide. Governments are moving towards age restrictions, while technology companies are being pushed to strengthen age assurance, parental controls and safer platform design. Meta, in a US lawsuit, has agreed to introduce features for teens to address concerns around addiction and excessive screen time. In India, the Supreme Court recently sought the Centre's response to a petition seeking safeguards against minors independently maintaining social-media accounts.

The concern is legitimate: children need protection online. But as India considers its response, it should also consider whether a blanket social media ban could deepen existing digital inequalities and widen gaps in children's opportunities to participate meaningfully online.

USE OF SOCIAL MEDIA
For much of the past decade, India's digital agenda has focused on narrowing the access divide through affordable mobile internet and smartphones. A

recent report (Ganguly *et al.*, 2026), based on the India Human Development Survey (IHDS-3, 2022-24), shows that 95.1 per cent of households own a mobile phone. Yet access to, and participation in, the digital world remain unequal among children and teenagers.

For many young people, social media and other online platforms are spaces for communication, information, creativity and social connection.

At the same time, India lacks evidence on how children use social media and which online experiences are harmful. ASER 2024 reports that 57 per cent of rural adolescents aged 14-16 who can use a smartphone used it for an education-related activity in the preceding week, but it does not identify the platforms used. The same platforms can serve educational and recreational purposes, making the boundary between “useful” and “harmful” online experiences less clear-cut.

The inequalities become clearer in social media use. The IHDS-3 report shows that among children aged 13-16 years, 65.3 per cent have access to a mobile device, 37.8 per cent use the internet, and 21.3 per cent use social media. Social media use is higher among boys than girls (26.4 per cent versus 16 per cent) and declines sharply from metropolitan areas (30.7 per cent) to



TRACKER. India lacks evidence on how children use social media

rural India (18.5 per cent). It increases steadily with parental education.

Children do not begin their digital lives from the same starting line. A teenager from a metropolitan, higher-educated household inhabits a different digital environment from a first-generation internet user in a rural household. A blanket restriction could therefore reduce exposure to online harms for some children while simultaneously removing opportunities for digital participation for others. Uniform regulation may not produce uniform outcomes in an unequal society.

None of this diminishes the harms associated with social media. Protecting children from cyberbullying, harmful content, addictive platform design, online exploitation and excessive use remains an important policy objective. But protection and participation should

not be treated as competing goals.

The emerging policy landscape offers more tools than a simple choice between unrestricted access and a blanket ban. Age assurance, parental controls, safer defaults, limits on harmful platform design and greater accountability for technology companies are increasingly part of the policy toolkit. For India, the challenge is to determine which combination of safeguards can reduce harm while preserving opportunities for children to learn, connect and develop digital capabilities. India should also assess the distributional consequences of any restriction — who is likely to lose access, who can compensate through other devices or support, and which children are already least able to participate online. These questions are central to equitable digital policy.

India's first digital divide was about who could get online. The next is about who can participate meaningfully and safely once connected. The goal should be to protect children online while keeping the door open to opportunities for learning, skill development and connection that the digital world can offer.

Ganguly is Associate Fellow, NCAER-National Data Innovation Centre, and Agarwal is Policy Analyst at The Quantum Hub. Views are personal

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

UPI dilemma
Apropos, 'FinMin will talk to IBA, other to ensure no MDR on consumers' (September 25). The proposed UPI Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), scheduled from October 15, has already triggered disquiet among businesses, particularly those operating on slender margins. Though the Finance Ministry may engage the Indian Banks' Association and traders to discourage merchants from transferring the cost to consumers, market behaviour could prove less compliant. Merchants facing an

additional transaction cost may either covertly pass it on through higher prices or discourage UPI payments altogether. Smaller businesses, lacking pricing flexibility, could be especially vulnerable. Government assurances cannot eliminate this commercial reality.
N Sadhasiva Reddy
Bengaluru
A robust platform
This refers to 'Taking stock' (September 25). Finally, the listing of NSE, the premier stock exchange of the country, has become a reality.

The robust trading platforms ranging from common stocks to commodities are the real strengths of the exchange. The functional efficiency of the stock exchange can be further improved by adopting new technologies like blockchain and AI to boost investor confidence and safeguard against systemic risks.
Sitaram Popuri
Bengaluru
Monitor forex flows
Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran has rightly observed that India has to look at both the

'emerging economy' tag: DEA Secretary' (September 25). India, with strong GDP growth and falling poverty, is steadily moving out of the emerging economy category. While recent FTAs with major economies are expanding trade and investment opportunities, the country's vast market, talent and global partnerships provide strong foundations for sustained growth. With continued reforms, innovation and inclusive growth, India can become a global economic power.
PV Prakash
Mumbai
India rising
This refers to 'India has outgrown

QUICKLY.

Cooperative banks to operate during strike

Mumbai: The cooperative banking sector has assured customers that banking services will continue uninterrupted during the three-day strike proposed by the United Forum of Bank Unions from September 28 to 30, 2026. Customers will continue to have access to branch banking services, agricultural and rural credit, business banking facilities, and digital channels such as ATMs, internet banking, mobile banking and UPI, depending on the services offered by individual banks. **OUR BUREAU**

Sundaram Home Fin to improve presence

Chennai: Sundaram Home Finance is expanding its presence in the emerging business (EB) segment in small towns in Tamil Nadu. The company, which opened a branch in Mannargudi on Friday, is targeting to almost double disbursements in this segment to nearly ₹200 crore in central Tamil Nadu this year. The company is looking to open EB branches in Karaikkal and Thiruthurai-poondi. **OUR BUREAU**

Trump, Xi review bilateral ties, vow to chart course over common interests

STRATEGIC GAINS. Xi called for translating the new vision of a constructive China-US relationship into action

Press Trust of India
Washington

President Donald Trump has said that the US and China have “never gotten along better” as he reviewed bilateral ties with his Chinese counterpart, Xi Jinping. He asserted that the two countries can continue to build a relationship that promotes prosperity and security for future generations.

Trump accorded a grand welcome, complete with military honours and a flyover by fighter jets, to Xi on Thursday, at the White House, followed by a meeting in the Oval Office that lasted over two hours.

At the State dinner in the White House, Trump and Xi raised a toast to the countries’ relationship.

“Americans and Chinese have always exchanged goods, knowledge, customs, and ideas. This has been the foundation of commerce and mutual respect between our



WARM VIBES. US President Donald Trump and First Lady Melania Trump greet Chinese President Xi Jinping and his wife Peng Liyuan at the White House in Washington, DC **REUTERS**

countries, and together we can continue to build a relationship that promotes prosperity and security for future generations,” Trump said.

HISTORIC TIES

“Today, President Trump and I had sincere and in-depth exchanges, and reached common understanding on many issues. This has added new substance to the constructive China-US relationship of

strategic stability,” Jinping said. Both leaders referred to historic ties between the US and China with Trump recalling the visit of first Chinese diplomats to Boston 158 years ago.

Xi reciprocated by recalling George Washington’s vast collection of Chinese porcelain and the cooperation between the two countries in the Second World War.

The gathering had guests such as Amazon’s Jeff Bezos,

Nvidia’s Jensen Huang, and Meta’s Mark Zuckerberg, OpenAI’s Sam Altman, Google’s Sundar Pichai, Tesla and SpaceX’s Elon Musk, Micron’s Sanjay Mehrotra, Microsoft’s Satya Nadella, Apple’s Tim Cook, Dell’s Michael Dell.

During the bilateral talks, Xi called for translating the new vision of a constructive China-US relationship of strategic stability into action and finding the right way for the two major countries to get along.

The Chinese leader also

drew the red line over the issue of Taiwan and counselled the US to handle the issue with prudence.

AI GUARDRAILS

On AI, Xi said China and the US should leverage their strengths in the sector rather than guarding against each other.

He said the two countries can continue to engage in dialogue on AI, exchange views on its risks and benefits, and work together to prevent its misuse and abuse.

1 lakh American exchange students invited to China

China’s President Xi Jinping on Thursday said one lakh young Americans will be invited to visit China for exchanges and study over the next five years.

The announcement by Xi at the White House here came against the backdrop of a similar announcement made in 2023, under which 50,000 young Americans were invited for exchanges and study over a five-year period. The target was achieved this year ahead of schedule.

Poly Medicure expands domestic manufacturing

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai



Himanshu Baid, MD, Poly Medicure Ltd

With two overseas acquisitions in the bag, medical devices maker Poly Medicure is focussing on shoring up its domestic manufacturing in segments including cardiac and orthopaedic products.

“So every year, the plan is [for] the next four years, by FY30, we plan to launch 25-30 new products every year,” said Himanshu Baid, Managing Director, Poly Medicure Ltd, adding that the focus would be on cardiac, orthopaedic, nephrology, gastro and oncology products.

“We have around 390 patents ...and we are working on a lot of new technologies, a lot of new devices, which we are trying to bring in. And most of these technologies are import substitution. So that is further going to help hospitals save costs and... reduce our dependency on foreign technology and foreign products,” Baid told **businessline**.

Late last year, Poly Medicure inked agreements to wholly acquire Italy-based

Citiffe Group at an enterprise value of ₹324 crore, besides a majority stake in Netherlands-based Pendra-Care Group at an enterprise value of ₹188.5 crore.

“We’re transferring some of the production to India. And this will help us to lower the cost,” he said. The integration following the two acquisitions were complete, Baid said, adding that nothing changes for the employees. However, all the additional capacity would come up in India, he said, of new facilities in Haryana, and a second in the medical park in Uttar Pradesh.

About 70 per cent of the company’s ₹1,875 crore revenues are from exports.

Mobile CNG could take gas pumps to mines, ports and heavy equipment

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

India is taking the CNG pump to the vehicle, opening mines, ports, railways, waterways and difficult-to-move heavy equipment to mobile gas refuelling in a move that could remove one of the biggest infrastructure barriers to replacing diesel in captive fleets.

Per the latest rules notified by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, mobile refuelling units (MRUs), can carry CNG and compressed biogas (CBG) dis-

persing equipment to approved locations and refuel onboard cylinders, including on heavy machinery that cannot be brought to a conventional filling station. CBG is a renewable substitute for CNG produced from agricultural, animal and other organic waste.

PUMP ON WHEELS

The model is similar to mobile diesel dispensing, which reversed the traditional fuel-retailing equation by taking fuel to large consumers instead of requiring vehicles to travel to a pump.

For CNG and CBG, the

change could be more significant because gas adoption depends on specialised compression, storage and dispensing infrastructure. A mine or industrial site considering switching equipment from diesel therefore faces not only the cost of changing vehicles but also the availability of refuelling infrastructure.

MRUs could change that equation. Gas can be loaded at designated areas of CNG mother stations or licensed CNG/CBG filling facilities and taken to an approved captive location, allowing distributors to serve demand

without first putting a conventional filling station at every customer site.

The rules specifically allow mobile refuelling of non-transport vehicles operating in mines and notified ports, Railways locomotives, approved ships and boats on inland and seaborne waterways, and engines undergoing testing at authorised laboratories.

The Chief Controller can also permit refuelling of heavy equipment, machinery and other heavy vehicles that cannot be brought to a fuel-dispensing station, subject to additional safeguards and



risk assessments. That could expand the opportunity beyond the applications explicitly listed in the rules and give city-gas distributors a way to build captive demand before committing capital to

permanent stations. CBG or compressed bio gas producers could be another beneficiary.

India’s emerging biogas industry needs customers as well as production capacity, and mobile dispensing provides a potential last-mile connection between licensed CBG facilities and concentrated users.

That could be particularly useful where a captive fleet provides meaningful demand but not enough initially to justify dedicated permanent dispensing infrastructure.

The government has, how-

ever, stopped well short of allowing unrestricted CNG pumps on wheels. MRUs cannot be used for public retail dispensing on public roads, residential areas, commercial parking areas, basements or other unapproved locations. CNG MRUs must be owned by the city-gas distributor authorised for the geographical area.

The safety requirements are also extensive. MRUs require approved storage cascades, dispensing systems and emergency shutdown equipment. Working pressure is generally capped at

250 bar, while units with water capacity exceeding 10,000 litres require specific permission.

THE COMMERCIAL TEST

The first commercial test will therefore come from captive fleets rather than motorists. IFMRUs allow gas companies to aggregate demand before building permanent stations, they could extend CNG and CBG into locations that have remained difficult to serve. Much as mobile fuel bowsters took diesel pumps to large customers, India’s new rules could allow the gas pump to start following the machine.

Revisit history with *The Hindu*’s special Gandhi Jayanthi edition

The Hindu Bureau
Chennai

This Gandhi Jayanthi, readers can own a slice of history. *The Hindu* is bringing out a commemorative reprint of the October 2, 1969 edition and the 2003 feature, ‘The Mahatma and The Hindu’.

The special Gandhi Jayanti commemorative edition brings together rare archival pages from its history. The edition

traces Gandhi’s journey from his early years as an attorney and activist in South Africa, to the moment of India’s Independence and features archival photographs capturing Gandhi at various moments in history.

The limited edition is available on Zepto ahead of Gandhi Jayanti across major Indian cities. Readers may place orders through <https://newsth.live/zepto-Oct2> or scan the code.

Dextr AI raises \$6.7 million in seed round

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Dextr AI, the AI agent platform for hospitality, has raised \$6.7 million seed round led by Elevation Capital, with participation from Foundation Capital. The capital will be used to accelerate product development, expand the team and scale Dextr AI’s deployments across hospitality markets globally. The platform allows hospitality employees to control teams of specialised AI agents across guest management and operations.

CAMPUS CONNECT



YOUTH WITH FM. Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman participated in an interactive session with students at M.O.P. Vaishnav College for Women in Chennai, on Friday. Around 130 students from 20 colleges were present at the event where the FM interacted with the students, and shared her views on a range of issues **BJOY GHOSH**

AI-powered experience guides 4 in 5 shoppers: InMobi Advertising report

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Indian millennials’ festive looks will be AI-approved this year as the generation outpaces tech-savvy GenZ in AI-assisted shopping, as per InMobi Advertising’s Marketer’s Guide to India’s Festive Season 2026 report.

AI is actively reshaping shopping experience, with features such as smart search suggestions (89 per cent) virtual product try-ons (81 per cent), AI-assisted brand discovery and decision-making. The technology moves discovery beyond the search action as 75 per cent of consumers said they paid attention to festive content on idle TV screens and 67 per cent said they used their mobile devices while watching television.

Four in five shoppers are

actively seeking AI-powered assistants to guide their festive purchases.

IDLE INFLUENCE

“Today’s shoppers expect hyper-relevant, frictionless discovery whether they are on their smart TV, lock screen, or everyday apps. For marketers, this means moving beyond high-volume advertising to creating AI-powered experiences that are useful in the moment, build brand trust and help consumers move seamlessly from discovery to decision,” said Pavitra Gupta, Vice President & General Manager - India, InMobi.

SHOPPING SPREE

Further, three in five shoppers plan to spend over ₹10,000 this festive season. The report notes that high spending intent spans across operating systems this year,

with Android users demonstrating higher purchasing confidence: 22 per cent plan to spend between ₹25,000 and ₹50,000. In comparison, 15 per cent of iOS users are willing to share as much even though both share equal representation in the ₹50,000+ budget bracket.

Consumers in tier-2 cities are emerging as a high-value segment, planning budgets in the ₹10,000-₹25,000 range at rates that match metro shoppers. As these diverse, high-intent consumer cohorts converge online, the festive basket is also expanding beyond traditional categories.

While apparel and footwear remain staple festive purchases (50 per cent), categories such as jewellery (40 per cent) and grocery/daily essentials (37 per cent) are also seeing strong purchase intent.

Google Cloud eyes India ties as AI adoption picks up

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Google Cloud is increasingly positioning its Marketplace programme as a route for technology partners to take their solutions to market and expand into newer geographies, as it deepens partnerships with Indian technology firms, according to Amit Kumar, Managing Director, Digital Natives Business at Google Cloud India.

On Google Cloud’s Marketplace, partners can list their solutions for customers to discover and deploy, while companies looking to enter new countries can work with local Google sales teams on market access and go-to-market partnerships.

Kumar added that the traditional concept of a customer is becoming less relevant, with relationships increasingly evolving into partnerships. This does not make the buying relationship

any less important, but places greater emphasis on partnership. “We don’t believe we are the only ones building a solution for India. Many times, Google builds a solution and has first-party products. Other times, we also work with partners, enabling them to build a product on our platform... Partnership is an important approach to a market as diverse as India,” he noted.

On Google Cloud Marketplace, partners can list their solutions. Once a solution is available on the Marketplace, any customer using Google Cloud can discover that solution there. The programme enables partners to go to market or even expand into a new country.

“Let’s say you build a solution with us and want to enter a new country. You can partner with the local Google sales teams on how to address that market and do GTM partnerships,” he added. Moreover, Kumar



noted that enterprises in India are moving beyond AI experimentation and beginning to deploy the technology at scale, with the focus increasingly shifting towards measurable business value, governance, and the use of different models for different workloads.

THE RIGHT KIND

As companies move into production, they are also becoming more selective about which models they use for different tasks rather than relying on a single model across an entire workflow. Kumar said companies are

evaluating models based on the intelligence, speed, latency, and cost required for individual tasks.

“Customers are understanding the workflow and which solutions work well more deeply,” he said. “In some places, you are looking at doing something at scale but don’t necessarily need a lot of intelligence. There, you are looking for a work-horse model.”

Google Cloud is also encouraging customers to use models beyond Google’s own offerings. Kumar said the company has around 200 models available on its model platform and follows an “optionality” approach across the technology stack.

Through its Model Garden on Gemini Enterprise, customers can access models of their choice, while Google’s customer engineers and forward-deployed engineers (FDEs) work with customers to identify models suited to specific use cases.

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM REGIONAL COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' UNION LTD.
(Affiliated to Kerala Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation Ltd.)
Head Office: "Kheera Bhavan", Pattom, Thiruvananthapuram - 695 004.
Phone: 0471-2447109, 2446845, 2448057; Fax: 2449567; email: ppm.trcmppu@gmail.com
E-TENDER NOTICE Date: 25.09.2026
E-tenders are invited for the supply of following items to TRCMPU:

E-TENDER ID	DESCRIPTION	APPROX. TENDER VALUE
2026_KCMFM_871196_1	E-TENDER FOR SUPPLY OF VETERINARY MEDICINES (FOR MANUFACTURERS)	Rs. 75.00 Lakhs
2026_KCMFM_871206_1	E-TENDER FOR SUPPLY OF VETERINARY MEDICINES AND SURGICALS (FOR MANUFACTURERS&DISTRIBUTORS)	Rs. 6.40 Lakhs

Specifications and details of the e-tender are available in the Government e-procurement portal (www.tenders.kerala.gov.in) and TRCMPU website (www.milmatrcmpu.com). Last date for submission of e-tender is on 06.10.2026, 12:00 PM
Managing Director

JAIPRAKASH POWER VENTURES LIMITED
Regd. Office: Complex of Jaypee Nigrie Super Thermal Power Plant, Nigrie Tehsil Sarai, Distt. Singrauli - 486669, (M.P.)
CIN: L40101MP1994PLC042920
Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) For 'Transportation of Ash' to Various Approved Avenues as per MOEF&CC/MOP Guideline
Jaiprakash Power Ventures Limited (JPVL) hereby invites bids for Road Transportation of Ash generated from its Jaypee Nigrie Super Thermal Power Plant, Distt: Singrauli (M.P.) and Jaypee Bina Thermal Power Plant, Distt: Sagar (M.P.), to various avenues during the contract period.
The detailed NIT for Tender No. JPVL/TENDER/02/2026-27 is available on the website www.jpvpowerventures.com under Tenders Tab. All corrigendum, addendum, amendments, time extension if any will be uploaded to above website and no corrigendum will be published in the press.
Show interest by 30.09.2026 along with the company profile in given mail ids. Last date of site visit/ verification and offer submission is 03.10.2026.
E-mail: binay.jha@jalindia.co.in (For Nigrie) and kk.mishra@jalindia.co.in (For Bina)

ASM Technologies Limited
(CIN L85110KA1992PLC013421)
Regd Office: 80/2 Lusanne Court Richmond Road, Bengaluru- 560025 Tel:080-66962300-02, Fax-08066962304, Email:info@asmtd.com, Website: www.asmtld.com
CORRIGENDUM TO THE NOTICE OF THE 01/2026-27 EXTRA-ORDINARY GENERAL MEETING
Members are hereby informed that:
This publication is a Corrigendum to the Notice dated September 09, 2026 (the "AGM Notice") convening the 01/2026-27 Extra-Ordinary General Meeting of the Members of ASM Technologies Limited (the "Company") to be held on Sunday, October 04, 2026, at 10:00 a.m. (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC")/Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM").
The said Notice of EGM was dispatched to the members on September 11, 2026, in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.
Pursuant to the MCA circulars, the Company has sent the electronic copies of the Corrigendum to the Notice of EGM on Friday, September 25, 2026, and the same was completed through electronic mode to those members whose email address are registered with the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent as on cut-off date for sending Notice i.e. September 04, 2026.
Pursuant to this corrigendum, the Explanatory Statement relating to Item No. 1 of the EGM Notice i.e. "To offer, issue and allot securities of the Company on preferential basis" shall be amended and shall incorporate the changes as mentioned in the corrigendum.
This Corrigendum to the EGM Notice shall form an integral part of the AGM Notice, which has already been circulated to the Shareholders of the Company and on and from the date hereof, the AGM Notice shall always be read in conjunction with this Corrigendum.
Copy of the said corrigendum to the AGM Notice is also uploaded on the website of the Company at www.asmtld.com, the websites of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com, and website of KFin at www.evoting.kfintech.com.
Rest all the details as mentioned in the EGM notice dated September 09, 2026 including all the process, notes and instructions relating to attending EGM through VCO/AVM, remote e-voting, and e-voting at the AGM shall remain same and there is no other change in the substance or content of the EGM Notice.
By Order of the Board
For ASM Technologies Limited
Sd/-
Vaniashree Kulkarni,
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer (M.No.: F13306)
Date : 26-09-2026
Place : Bengaluru

QUICKLY.

Mounting rate hike bets take dazzle off gold



Gold prices edged down on Friday and were headed for a weekly loss as concerns about sticky inflation and hawkish signals from the Fed dented bullion's appeal. Spot gold was down 0.1 per cent at \$4,274.18 per ounce by 1400 GMT. US gold futures rose 0.3 per cent to \$4,310.80. REUTERS

Copper up on weaker \$, tight Chinese supplies

London: Copper prices crept higher boosted by a weaker dollar and shortages in China but the gains were modest as investors remained wary about the potential for more rate hikes. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME rose 0.2 per cent to \$14,645 a tonne. Zinc climbed to its strongest in two weeks at \$3,989.50. REUTERS

Crude oil slides on US-Iran truce hopes



London: Crude oil prices fell as markets weighed the possibility of a truce between the US and Iran against concerns that increasing attacks against Saudi Arabia could disrupt supply. Brent was down 40 cents at \$106.20 a barrel by 0821 GMT, while US WTI was \$1.02 lower at \$93.59 a barrel. For the week, Brent so far has gained 2.2 per cent and WTI has dropped 6.8 per cent. REUTERS

High input costs, policy support may keep steel prices higher than in 2025

REALTY WOES. But weakness in the construction sector and China's property sector downturn will cap the offtake

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Global steel prices are expected to rule above 2025 levels, driven by higher input costs and policy-driven support in Western markets.

However, weakness in the construction sector and China's property sector downturn will cap steel offtake, analysts said.

"While higher steelmaking costs and trade-related supply constraints will continue to provide a floor under global steel prices in Q4, these forces are no longer driving clear upside," said research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions.

MODEST GROWTH Prices are likely to remain caught between cost-led support and mounting demand-side pressure as macroeconomic headwinds, elevated geopolitical tensions and China's subdued property sector weigh on the consumption outlook, it said.

The World Steel Organisation (worldsteel), in its short-range outlook, said the market was transitioning to a path of modest growth in 2026, with a more pronounced acceleration projected for 2027.

"This broader recovery is being driven by distinct shifts in regional dynamics. In China, the rate of demand contraction is finally decelerating in 2026, while demand growth across key developing markets, most notably India, remains vibrant," it said.

The Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) said the global steel industry is facing persistent challenges that are likely to intensify in 2026 and beyond.

"Global steel excess capacity is projected to grow through 2028 amid sluggish steel demand growth. Capacity utilisation could fall, intensifying downward pressure on the industry's profitability," it said.

BMI said it was maintain-



DENT IN DEMAND. worldsteel expects the ongoing West Asia conflict to result in a sharp decline in the region's steel demand in 2026, while the Gulf region was positioned for strong growth

ing its 2026 global steel price forecast at \$620/tonne.

PRICE OUTLOOK "While prices are expected to recover from 2025 levels, the rebound remains limited, with our 2026 forecast only slightly above the 2025 average of \$585," it said.

The research agency expects steel prices to remain range-bound for the rest of the year, with risks tilted to the downside.

worldsteel expects the ongoing conflict in West Asia to result in a sharp drop in that region's steel demand for 2026. The Gulf region was positioned for strong growth.

"After a protracted period of decline, we expect to see all major developed economies, including the European Union, the US, Canada, Japan and Korea, posting positive growth in 2027," it said.

OECD said the industry is

facing significant trade and adjustment challenges. Competition is being distorted by increasing subsidisation of the steel industry, mainly outside of the OECD area. "The pervasive use of subsidies is severely distorting competition and weakening the market function of the sector," it said.

CHINA INVESTMENTS The World Steel Association expects contraction in Chinese steel demand to narrow to -1.5 per cent this year, as the housing market correction nears its bottom.

Infrastructure investments in the country are expected to edge up this year, supported by local government efforts to maintain moderately strong GDP growth.

But steel demand across developing economies, excluding China, is projected to moderate to a 2.5 per cent growth in 2026, a significant deceleration from the nearly 5 per cent annual growth recorded in recent years.

India's steel output rises 4.6% in August even as global production declines

Gayathri G
Chennai

India's crude steel production rose 4.6 per cent year-on-year to 14.8 million tonnes (mt) in August, even as global output declined 1.2 per cent, according to data from the World Steel Association (worldsteel).

India remained the world's second-largest crude steel producer during the month, behind China, which produced 74.6 mt, down 3.7 per cent from August 2025. The US was the third-largest producer with an estimated output of 7.3 mt, up 3 per cent. Japan produced 6.7 mt, while Russia and South Korea produced 5.5 mt and 5.4 mt, respectively.

Global crude steel production across the 70 countries reporting to worldsteel stood at 144.2 mt in August, compared with 145.9 mt a year earlier. These countries accounted for about 98 per cent of global crude steel production in 2025.

OTHER PRODUCERS For the January-August

period, India's crude steel production increased 6 per cent year-on-year to 115.9 mt. This compares with a 3.1 per cent decline in China's output to 651.9 mt during the period.

Global production fell 0.7 per cent to 1.225 billion tonnes.

Asia and Oceania, the largest steel-producing region, accounted for 106.7 mt in August, down 1.4 per cent year-on-year. The decline was largely influenced by lower Chinese output.

Among other major producers, South Korea's output rose 2.6 per cent, while Germany's increased 1.7 per cent. Vietnam recorded a sharp 36.4 per cent increase to 2.7 mt. Brazil's production fell 6.2 per cent to 2.7 mt.

Region-wise, North America recorded a 3.9 per cent increase in output, while Africa's production rose 8.8 per cent.

Production declined in West Asia, South America, and Russia and other CIS countries, apart from Ukraine, by 4.6 per cent, 4.9 per cent and 5.6 per cent, respectively.

Exports of pulses record a five-fold growth in the past 10 years

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Premium geographical indication-tagged tur dal from Kalaburagi in Karnataka has found its way to the Maldives, even as overseas demand for pulses continues to rise. Overall exports, which crossed a million tonnes and were within striking distance of a billion dollar mark during financial year 2025-26, have sustained the trend in the current year on strong overseas demand.

In the April-July period of the current financial year, exports were up 45 per cent in value terms at \$452.27 million from the corresponding last year's \$311.08 million. In volume terms, pulses exports during April-July stood at over 4.94 lakh tonnes (lt), an increase of 59 per cent over the corresponding last year's 3.10 lt.

India is the largest producer and consumer of pulses. Though the country has been a net importer, the overseas demand for Indian pulses, including the processed

ones, has been on the rise in recent years.

In fact over the past decade, pulses exports have witnessed a five-fold growth both in value and volumes (see table).

GI PRODUCTS Moong bean, kabuli chana, tur dal and lentils, among others, continue to witness a strong demand from countries such as China, the United Arab Emirates, Bangladesh and the US, with premium geographical indication (GI)-tagged products

also witnessing demand, of late.

"Gulbarga tur dal heads to the Maldives. 1 MT of the GI-tagged premium pulse from Karnataka, known for its exceptional taste, has been exported to the Maldives," Union Commerce Minister, Piyush Goyal posted on X.

"The farmers who have made this possible with their hard work get over 30 per cent higher prices for their produce in international markets," Goyal said.

The development highlights the export potential

for premium Indian pulses, in general, and GI tagged products, in particular, to help farmers access overseas markets and improve their realisation.

The trade, which is bullish about the prospects for pulses exports, wants a favourable export policy from the government.

"India can become a good exporter of pulses in the years to come, and we need a favourable policy from the government in terms of incentivising exports," said Bimal Kothari, Chairman, In-

dia Pulses and Grains Association.

FOREX OUTGO OFFSET "While we are importing around six million tonnes of pulses, we are exporting around a million tonnes, some of which is processed, offsetting the foreign exchange outgo to an extent," he said.

"China is buying a large quantity of moong beans from us. We are self-sufficient in moong beans and the government should continue to allow that," Kothari said.

Up and rising

Financial year	Value (\$ million)	Quantity (tonnes)
2016-17	191.76	1,36,968
2017-18	228.32	1,80,193
2018-19	263.04	2,89,617
2019-20	214.89	2,35,699
2020-21	284.26	2,96,169
2021-22	379.75	4,10,375
2022-23	672.31	7,75,024
2023-24	686.93	6,26,653
2024-25	854.96	7,93,291
2025-26	969.58	10,00,547

Source: DGCI

Dhanuka Agritech launches 'Polin' fungicide for paddy

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Dhanuka Agritech Ltd has announced the rollout of 'Polin', a fungicide developed through its strategic technical collaboration with Japan's Nippon Soda Co Ltd (NISSO) to protect rice crops against leaf and neck blast disease.

A media statement said that the formulation features dual translaminar and systemic mobility, penetrating crop tissue to protect unsprayed leaf areas and newly emerging plant growth.

Applied at a calibrated dose of 100 ml per acre in 200 litres of water, Polin provides long lasting residual control when applied at the first sign of infection during the critical crop growth stages.

By extending the protection window, the solution reduces overall spray frequency,

directly lowering labour and chemical expenses for rice growers, it said. Polin has been launched across different parts of Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, where Dhanuka has initiated awareness drives among paddy farmers to promote effective management of leaf and neck blast disease.

JAPANESE CHEMISTRY Quoting Rahul Dhanuka, MD of Dhanuka Agritech Ltd, the statement said: "With Polin, we are delivering patented Japanese chemistry with a completely new mode of action for the control of rice blast. It gives farmers deeper and more durable protection from blast to healthy grains, cutting out repetitive spray costs."

The company would be launching more solutions to help farmers in the coming months, Dhanuka added.

Centre clears excess tobacco sale in A.P.

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The Centre has cleared the way for flue-cured Virginia tobacco farmers in Andhra Pradesh to sell their excess and 'unauthorised' crop from the 2025-26 season through the Tobacco Board's auction platforms.

"The decision gives farmers, who produced excess tobacco, a chance to sell at authorised auction platforms. It also allows registered buyers to purchase it legally," Tobacco Board Chairman Yashwanth Chidipothu said.

In a gazette notification on Thursday, the Commerce Ministry authorised the Tobacco Board to allow registered traders and dealers to buy excess FCV tobacco from registered farmers and unauthorised crop from unregistered growers.

CIS buyers lift orthodox tea prices in Kochi sales

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

Active participation of CIS buyers pushed tea prices, especially of the orthodox varieties, at the Kochi auctions this week.

There was a strong demand for orthodox and CTC leaves, with orthodox witnessing 95 per cent sale out of the offered quantity of 2,53,035 kg. In CTC leaf, the sale was 100 per cent out of the offered quantity of 30,087 kg, auctioneers Forbes, Ewart & Figgis said.

However, some traders attributed the price rise to low offerings, which reflected in the price movement. Rain in production centres have hit tea arrivals to the auction platform.

MIXED TREND Anil George Joseph, Presid-

ent of the Tea Trade Association of Cochin, said the orthodox market witnessed good demand, though the trend was mixed.

Whole-leaf grades were irregular and tended easier, while mid-leaf and larger brokens were firm to occasionally dearer. Other grades eased depending on quality.

Popular and good-liquoring CTC sorts were fully firm to occasionally dearer, while medium grades followed a similar trend. Well-made, blacker and plainer teas also gained value, he said.

In CTC dust, the market was lower by ₹1-2 a kg, while the popular marks of Kerala, especially powdery grades, appreciated. The offered quantity was 6,03,842 kg with 90 per cent sales. Dust orthodox was firm to dearer with 100 per cent sale out of the offered quantity of 4,850 kg.

Agrograde working on AI-based garlic, tomato sorting and grading machines

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Agri-robotics start-up Agrograde is working on artificial intelligence (AI)-powered optical sorting, grading, weighing and warehouse automation machines for tomato, garlic and leafy vegetables, founder and CEO Kshitij Thakur said.

The Pune-based company is currently providing such services for onions, potatoes, apples and arecanuts. "Maybe sometime next year, we'll have something for tomato. And then we'll see how it goes," the company's founder said. Spices are a sector the company would want to enter.

Launched in 2018, Agrograde has deployed over 130 machines across 14 States and four crop value chains. "We recently in-



Agrograde Founder and CEO Kshitij Thakur

stalled one machine for arecanut in Karnataka, which checks for any kind of physical damage or defects, and then sorts it," Thakur told *businessline* in an online interaction.

Agrograde is one of the leading players in technology in the onion market.

"We are seeing adoption closer to farm gate. So farmer producer organisations (FPOs), aggregators and exporters are our primary customers. Our suc-

cess is also because the manual processes in sorting, grading and packing are becoming inefficient," he said.

For example, manually, any aggregator would be incurring a cost of ₹0.4-₹1 a kg, depending on the location.

"Our work has drastically reduced costs to ₹0.08-0.1 a kg for grading and sorting, with around 99 per cent accuracy in terms of size. We have also reduced the handling losses that used to typically happen during these processes," said Thakur.

WAVE MOTION TECH Deploying wave motion technology, the machines, deployed near agricultural produce marketing committee yards, have been built with deep learning power or AI-powered sorting machines. At least 12 images of each product that goes through is captured.

Vedanta Aluminium emerges 2nd largest SEZ goods exporter

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Vedanta Aluminium, with its special economic zone (SEZ) in Jharsuguda, Odisha, has emerged as India's second largest SEZ goods exporter.

Citing the latest trade figures compiled by the Export Promotion Council for export oriented units (EOUs) and SEZs, a company statement said that it had contributed \$3.5 billion in exports in 2025-26, which translates to 6 per cent of India's total SEZ goods exports.

Vedanta Aluminium's exports serve customers in over 60 countries across Europe, the US, Japan and South-East Asia, among other global markets. Sustained demand from these markets — several of which enforce stringent quality, en-



The company contributed \$3.5 billion in exports in 2025-26, translating to 6% of total SEZ goods exports

vironmental and compliance standards — underscores the company's manufacturing excellence and its ability to meet the exacting specifications required by global automotive, aerospace and industrial customers, it said.

QUALITY STANDARDS Vedanta Aluminium's export

basket spans its full range of primary and value-added products, including billets, wire rods, rolled products, primary foundry alloys and ingots, alongside its low-carbon 'Restora' aluminium range.

These products serve critical applications across automotive, aerospace, electrical, construction and packaging industries, as well as emerging applications linked to renewable energy, electric mobility, AI infrastructure and data centres.

Quoting Rajesh Kumar, CEO of Vedanta Aluminium, the statement said: "As India's SEZs play an increasingly vital role in the country's trade story, we remain committed to expanding our capabilities and contributing to the nation's ambition of becoming a global manufacturing and export hub."

'Climate resilience is now central to IIHR breeding programme'

bl interview

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The ICAR-Indian Institute of Horticultural Research (IIHR), Bengaluru, the premier horticulture research institute recently celebrated its 60th Foundation Day. Over the past six decades, IIHR has played a key role in the country's horticulture revolution, releasing over 350 varieties of fruits and vegetables and over 163 technologies.

IIHR Director Tusar Kanti Behera spoke about the latest developments at the institute and its plans. The greater challenge than innovation is the last mile delivery, he said.

Edited excerpts:

Which recent IIHR varieties and technologies have the



We are developing varieties tolerant to drought, heat, erratic rainfall and emerging pests and diseases in tomato, chilli, brinjal, onion, mango, papaya, guava

TUSAR KANTI BEHERA
Director, IIHR

greatest potential to transform farmer incomes?

IIHR has released over 350 crop varieties and numerous production technologies. Recent high-impact innovations include Arka Abhed (tomato), Arka Meghana (chilli), Arka Savi (rose), improved guava, dragon fruit, avocado and pomegranate varieties, along with precision fertigation and protected cultivation technologies.



These technologies typically enhance farmer incomes through higher productivity of 20-40 per cent, better tolerance to diseases and climate stress, improved shelf life and market quality, and reduced input costs through efficient water and nutrient management.

Adoption of these varieties is expanding through State Horticulture Departments, Kisan Vikas Kendras (KVKs), farmer producer or-

ganisations (FPOs) and licensed seed partners across several States.

What are the major gaps between research and largescale adoption? How is IIHR trying to bridge this research-to-farm gap?

The greater challenge than innovation is last-mile delivery. Major gaps include limited availability of quality planting material, inadequate extension support, low awareness, fragmented value chains and weak market linkages.

IIHR is addressing these through largescale breeder and foundation seed production, technology demonstrations and farmer participatory trials, establishment of mother blocks and nurseries, collaboration with KVKs, State departments, FPOs and private entrepreneurs, digital advisories and capacity-building programmes. The objective is to shorten

the time between laboratory innovation and field adoption.

Climate change has become the norm. What climate-resilient varieties and technologies is IIHR developing?

Climate resilience is now central to IIHR's breeding programme. We are developing varieties tolerant to drought, heat, erratic rainfall and emerging pests and diseases in tomato, chilli, brinjal, onion, mango, papaya, guava and other horticultural crops.

Important technologies include climate-resilient rootstocks, micro-irrigation and fertigation, rainwater harvesting, protected cultivation, precision nutrient management, integrated pest and disease management using biological solutions. These help maintain productivity while reducing water and chemical inputs.

QUICKLY.

Mumbai ranked 8th globally in prime realty

Mumbai: Mumbai has been ranked eighth globally in Knight Frank's Prime Global Cities Index, with a 6.2 per cent rise in real estate prices in the second quarter of 2026. The Prime Global Cities Index tracks the movement of prime residential prices across 46 cities. Bengaluru was ranked 12th with 4.5 per cent growth and New Delhi 17th with 3.9 per cent growth. **OUR BUREAU**

Cochin Shipyard acquires 23% stake in Conoship

Cochin Shipyard has signed a Share Purchase Agreement to acquire a 23 per cent stake in the Netherlands-based ship design and engineering company Conoship International Holding BV. The deal is valued at a cash consideration of €2.30 million (₹25 crore), the company said in a stock exchange filing. The deal has received clearance from the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management. **OUR BUREAU**

NDA allies urge poll panel to dispel misgivings in people's minds on SIR

DISSENT ERUPTS. Opposition begins protest after Rahul Gandhi demands resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Two NDA allies — Lok Jan-shakti Party leader and Union Minister of Food Processing Industries Chirag Paswan and Rashtriya Lok Morcha leader Upendra Kushwaha — on Friday joined the debate on Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's conduct, asking the Election Commission of India to “dispel misgivings in the minds of the people” arising out of reports of alleged internal differences within the poll panel over Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Though the BJP came out to defend the Election Commission of India and Chief Election Commissioner Kumar, who is at the centre of controversy, Paswan stressed in Patna, “Let me make it clear that, as part of

the government, I do not intend to defend a constitutional body. I am also not very worried about the allegations made by the opposition, which will always take a stand that suits it politically.” The Union Minister was speaking to reporters. As per news reports, Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi wrote 14 times over the course of 10 days about the deletion and addition of voters to the electoral roll, as well as on other issues.

VOTER CONFIDENCE “If the people start losing trust in the electoral system, that will not augur well for democracy. Therefore, I think the Election Commission must come out with its clarification more forcefully. It need not respond to what Rahul Gandhi and his associates are saying, but it must dispel the misgivings in the



RIISING VOICES. Police use water cannons against Congress protesters as they attempt to march to the office of the Bihar State Election Commission

minds of the people,” said the Hajipur MP. Upendra Kushwaha, who is also a Rajya Sabha MP, said on X: “There is a lot of confusion among the public about SIR. This issue needs to be addressed. Election Commission has to clarify this without delay.”

CONGRESS PROTEST Meanwhile, the Opposition continued with its protest

after the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, demanded the resignation of the CEC and charged that recent elections were rigged by the Commission. The Congress staged protests by attempting to march towards state election commission offices in various States, demanding Kumar's immediate arrest, removal from office and an

independent review of all decisions and electoral roll changes made under him. It also accused the Election Commission of carrying out an “unprecedented attack” on voter equality by allegedly creating a specific ‘Mark VIP’ feature in the BLO application and urged Kumar to either turn “aprover” or face trial. Congress Deputy Leader in the Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi was among the several leaders and workers who were detained as the police used barricades to stop them from marching towards the Election Commission offices in various States. Meanwhile, the Delhi Police detained Dipankar Bhat-tacharya of the CPI(ML) (Liberation), student activist Neha Bora of AISA, social activist Yogendra Yadav and others at the Jantar Mantar as they were demanding the arrest of the CEC.

Can tourism help Salamabad gain back jobs lost after LoC trade ban?

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

For Mukhtar Ahmad, Salamabad in north Kashmir's Uri was once a workplace where the movement of trucks provided regular livelihood. As a loader at the Trade Facilitation Centre, he handled the loading and unloading of goods during the years when cross-LoC trade was operational. That work disappeared when trade was suspended in 2019. “But now that the facility is being used for tourism, I believe I may find some work again,” Ahmad said. Cross-LoC trade between

India and Pakistan began in 2008 as a confidence-building measure between the two countries. The barter-based trade continued for more than a decade before it was suspended in April 2019. The Centre, in an order issued by the Ministry of Home Affairs, had said the trade routes had been misused by Pakistan-based elements for funnelling illegal weapons, narcotics and fake Indian currency. The shutdown, however, affected more than traders. Around 25,000 people were estimated to have depended directly or indirectly on the trade, including workers and businesses linked to the movement of goods.



UNCERTAIN OUTLOOK. Tourism could create a different set of job opportunities, but the scale remains unclear

JOB GENERATION Seven years later, the Salamabad Trade Facilitation Centre is being given a new purpose. The Tourism De-

partment has taken over the facility and is exploring its use for border tourism. Tourism could create a different set of opportunities, but the

scale of employment it may generate remains unclear. Advocate Naveed, a social activist, said the decision to convert the facility into a

tourism centre would not help revive the livelihoods lost after the suspension of cross-LoC trade. “The centre has had its own historic significance,” he said. Officials have also indicated that local youth could be involved in tourism services and related activities. Uri MLA Sajad Shafi said, “Converting it into a tourism facility could provide new job opportunities for unemployed youth in the area.” **EARLY DAYS** However, it is too early to say how the government plans to develop the facility; he maintained that Uri had considerable potential for religious and border tourism.

Tamil Nadu likely to receive normal North-East monsoon rainfall: TN Agri University forecast

Gayathri G
Chennai



BELOW PAR. Tamil Nadu received 254 mm rainfall during the South-West Monsoon, against the normal of 292 mm as of September 22

Tamil Nadu is expected to receive normal rainfall during the North-East monsoon 2026, with the seasonal total forecast around 468 mm, marginally above the long period average (LPA) of 464 mm, according to the Tamil Nadu Agricultural University (TNAU). The forecast, prepared at a 60 per cent probability level using the Southern Oscillation Index (SOI) and the Sea Surface Temperature (SST) values of the Pacific and Indian Oceans during July-August, was generated using the Australian Rainman International V4.3 software.

EL NINO IMPACT The State received 254 mm during the South-West monsoon (June-September) against the normal 292 mm,

recording a 13 per cent deficit as of September 22. The N-E monsoon, which contributes nearly half of Tamil Nadu's annual rainfall, is, therefore, expected to provide some relief to soil moisture, reservoir storage and groundwater recharge, a press release from the university said.

However, the university cautioned that the prevailing El Nino conditions could influence monsoon circulation and result in uneven rainfall distribution. Coastal districts could experience intense wet spells associated with cyclonic systems, while interior districts may see more dry spells, particularly

in December. The district-level forecast points to considerable variation around the State average. Chennai, with normal North-East monsoon rainfall of 751 mm, is forecast to receive 730 mm, a 3 per cent deficit. **WATER MANAGEMENT** The TNAU has advised farmers to make use of weather forecasts and agro-advisories for decisions on sowing, irrigation and fertilizer application. It also recommended harvesting and storing excess rainwater in farm ponds for use during subsequent dry periods. While the North-East Monsoon is critical for agriculture and water resources, the distribution of rainfall across districts, rather than the seasonal aggregate alone, is likely to remain important for farm operations and reservoir management during October-December.

ARTISTRY ON DISPLAY



WEAVING TRADITION. 19-year-old Tarika, daughter of Srivats Ram, CMD, Wheels India, is presenting her handwoven tapestry, inspired by South Indian saree patterns and as a celebration of India's handloom tradition, at a two-day exhibition at Taneira, Adyar. The exhibition was inaugurated on Friday and the works will be available for public viewing till 7 pm on Saturday

SC backs Delhi HC forensic audit order of Fortis-Singh brothers deal

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday rejected a plea by Fortis Healthcare Ltd against the forensic audit of the company's and its former promoters' transactions allegedly linked to a ₹3,500 crore arbitral award passed in favour of Japanese pharma major Daiichi Sankyo. On August 31, the Delhi High Court had ordered the forensic audit of Fortis and its former promoters Malvinder Mohan Singh and Shivinder Mohan Singh. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing a plea filed by Fortis Healthcare and refused to interfere with the High Court order. “We see no reason to interfere with the impugned judgment of the Delhi High Court,” the bench said.

COURT'S OBSERVATION The top court also observed that the Delhi High Court's observations against Fortis, justifying the forensic audit, are only tentative and *prima facie*.

TN outlines next phase of industrial growth

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu is pursuing an ambitious growth agenda, with a focus on advanced manufacturing, semiconductors, shipbuilding, artificial intelligence, space technology and global capability centres, Industries Minister S Keerthana said on Friday. Addressing virtually a session, titled *Tamil Nadu: Vetri Tamizhagam - Building a Global Growth and Investment Powerhouse*, at the 13th annual forum of the Public Affairs Forum of India (PAFI) in Delhi, the Minister highlighted the State's ongoing reforms to make investing and operating in Tamil Nadu more predictable, including time-bound appro-

vals, a proposed 21-day deemed-approval framework, and a new Investment Promotion Commission, among other measures. She invited industry participants to share their concerns, challenges and criticisms candidly with the government. Deepak Jacob, MD & CEO, Guidance TN, outlined the ‘Vetri Tamil Nadu’ vision and highlighted the State's continued engagement with investors and industry stakeholders. The next phase will focus on advanced manufacturing, R&D, GCCs and emerging sectors, while continuing to promote district-led industrial development. The session also highlighted the State's approximately 72 per cent MoU conversion rate.

Sarah Peluse wins Sastra-Ramanujan Award

Our Bureau
Chennai

Researcher Sarah Peluse, Associate Professor of Mathematics at Stanford University, has bagged the prestigious Sastra-Ramanujan Award for the year 2026. Her contributions to the field of analytic number theory, additive combinatorics, combinatorial geometry and group theory have created several breakthroughs in advanced problems, Sastra University said in a statement. The Sastra-Ramanujan Award carries a cash prize of \$10,000 and a citation. It shall be presented to Professor Peluse on December 22, Srinivasa Ramanujan's birthday, at the Sastra campus.

J&K Assembly descends into chaos after CM moves resolution seeking restoration of full statehood

Our Bureau
Srinagar

Proceedings in the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly descended into chaos on Friday after Chief Minister Omar Abdullah moved a resolution seeking restoration of full statehood to the Union Territory. In the resolution, Abdullah referred to two earlier resolutions passed by the Assembly — on June 26, 2000, seeking restoration of the autonomy that the region had lost and in November 6, 2024, in its first session after Jammu and Kashmir was downgraded to a Union Territory, seeking restoration of its special status. As the Chief Minister moved the latest resolution,



UP IN ARMS. BJP members protesting in the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly on Friday **IMRAN NISSAR**

BJP legislators rose from their seats and entered the well of the House, protesting against the references to the earlier resolutions. **‘NOT ANTI-NATIONAL’** The legislators tore copies of the resolution and called it “anti-national.” Speaker Abdul Rahim

Rather adjourned the House for half an hour. Speaking to reporters later, Abdullah challenged the BJP to “show a single anti-national word in the resolution”. He said the resolution seeking restoration of statehood was distinct from the earlier resolutions passed by

Plea in SC says CEC can be probed and tried like an ‘ordinary accused’

Krishnadas Rajagopal
New Delhi

A petition filed in the Supreme Court on Friday sought the constitution of an independent, high-powered Judicial Inquiry Commission or Special Investigation Team headed by a retired apex court judge to probe the allegations relating to the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

The plea said such an investigation must encompass, among others, an end-to-end audit of the Election Commission databases and the institutional circumstances under which 13 crore names were deleted across 30 States/union territories under the SIR. The plea filed by Supreme Court advocate Shaileendra Mani Tripathi, represented by advocate Chand Qureshi, submitted that Kumar should be divested of any statutory or constitutional immunity. The CEC remains directly accountable under the law, subject to police investigation, evidence gathering, and regular trial proceedings as an “ordinary accused.”

Tripathi argued that the allegations against Kumar in an investigative newspaper report did not show any reasonable nexus with his official functions and responsibilities and included tampering with the electoral roll. The allegations constitute a cognisable offence under Section 32 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, as well as the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

‘REASONABLE NEXUS’ “Once the logical and legal coherence between the act and the official obligation ceases to exist, the doctrine of ‘reasonable nexus’ breaks down completely. In the ab-

sence of this legal nexus, the statutory protection available under Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners Act, 2023, becomes entirely ineffective,” the petition contended. The petition follows media reports that official files revealed that the two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, had formally recorded written dissents and objections on at least 14 separate occasions, including four times on a single day, over a 10-month period, against “unilateral, unauthorised, and illegal decisions” taken and executed by Kumar in the name of the Election Commission.

CRIMINAL CONDUCT The petition said that the “illegal” acts included the unilateral alteration of the statutory Form 6 to introduce a mandatory ancestral condition or ‘last SIR linkage’ for first-time young voters, without legislative authority or amendment of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960; disenfranchisement due to software failures; and unauthorised subversion in West Bengal by filing over 16.10 lakh unauthorised appeals in the name of the EC to purge citizens restored by 700 judicial officers without the knowledge, authorisation, or sanction of the other two Election Commissioners or the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of West Bengal, etc. Tripathi said the status of a public servant by itself did not confer legal legitimacy or protection upon malicious or criminal conduct. “Intentionally manipulating records, committing forgery, or subverting the constitutional electoral process in the course of discharging official duties can under no circumstances be treated as an integral part of those duties,” the petition said.

A white Akasa Air aircraft is shown on a runway. The name "Akasa Air" is written in blue on the side of the fuselage. The aircraft has orange accents on the tail and engine nacelles.

Microsoft on Friday unveiled several new capabilities in its Copilot app, including a coding tool and an always-on AI agent, as the software giant seeks to transform its AI assistant into a one-stop shop for office workers. The company is also embedding Microsoft Office applications Word, Excel, and PowerPoint directly within Copilot. REUTERS

The rating methodology evaluates properties on parameters, such as fibre readiness, mobile network availability, in-building connectivity solutions and wi-fi infrastructure, with



“The DCR Platform facilitates implementation of the framework prescribed under the TRAI (Rating of Properties for Digital Connectivity) Regulations, 2024, as

MARKET AWARENESS

He said that the platform would also encourage property managers to plan digital connectivity infrastructure at the appropriate stage of property development. He also noted that the framework would initially operate

On asked about commercial cost of certification, he said the regulator would not regulate prices directly. While

"This regulation prohibits exclusive arrangements between the service providers and the property builders," Lahoti added.

A graphic featuring the Vodafone logo and '5G' text in white and yellow on a red background. A silhouette of a person is shown holding a device, with a signal wave emanating from it.

"A few days ago, we told you Vi was changing. A promise is only as good as the proof that follows. Today we deliver the first proof of that promise – solving a major consumer pain point," said Abhijit Kishore, CEO of Vi, in a message to customers.

Additionally, the induction of 60 Airbus A350 aircraft, starting from 2028 is expected to significantly increase IndiGo's cargo-carrying capacity on longer routes.

"That is why we have started focusing on the Arab market," said the Minister, describing how he attended the Arabian travel market, where Kerala Tourism put up a roadshow. "We had an Indo-Arab connect in Kerala too," he said.

Roche, which was founded in Basel in 1896, reported CHF 61.5 billion in Group sales in 2025.

